

FOURTH SERIES
VOL. 130
No. 23



THURSDAY
27th NOVEMBER, 2025

PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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*Published by Office of Chamber Reporting,
Parliament House, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by Publishing Department,
Parliament House, Accra.*

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Thursday, 27th November, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 1:02 p.m.*

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN
SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN,
IN THE CHAIR]
[PRAYERS]

[Pause]

1:12 p.m.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we would now take the item numbered 4. I have a Statement to make; a Formal Communication and also a ruling. The Formal Communication has to do with what happened yesterday when the Second Deputy Speaker was presiding. I watched the proceedings and particularly, the issue concerning the court order on the rerun of the Kpandai Parliamentary election.

**FORMAL COMMUNICATION BY
THE SPEAKER**

**Order for Rerun of the Kpandai
Parliamentary Election**

Hon Members, on Tuesday, 25th November, 2025, the Legal Services Office of the House was served with an order from the Tamale High Court, directed at the Clerk to Parliament. Per

the order, the court had ordered the second respondent, that is the Electoral Commission, to rerun the Kpandai Parliamentary election within 30 days.

Hon Members, this order arises out of the election petition filed by Daniel Nsala Wakpal, challenging the declaration of the Electoral Commission of Matthew Nyindam as Member of Parliament-elect for the Kpandai Constituency, pursuant to the Kpandai Parliamentary elections held on 7th December, 2024.

1:22 p.m.

Hon Members, the effect of the order, to my understanding, is that the Electoral Commission is to conduct a rerun election within 30 days, implying that the original declaration of Hon Matthew Nyindam as the winner of the parliamentary election is invalid and the Member is no longer a Member of Parliament.

I, however, bring to the attention of the House the provisions of the Court of Appeal Rules, 1997, C.I. 19 as amended in the Court of Appeal Rules, 2020, C.I. 132 Rule 27(3) and it provides as follows. I quote:

“There shall be a stay of execution of the judgement or decision appealed against for a period of seven days immediately following the giving of notice of the judgement or decision.”

This rule appears mandatory in its terms and applies in every High Court

decision capable of appeal. The Supreme Court in *Mensah v. Ghana Commercial Bank (GCB) 2005-2006*, the Supreme Court of Ghana Law Report on page 388, held that any execution commenced before the expiry of this seven-day period is premature and void. The Court of Appeal reaffirmed this position in *Klenam Construction Limited v. Falcon Crest Investment Limited & Others*, 7th April, 2022, emphasising that the purpose of the statutory stay is to allow the losing party the opportunity to consider the judgement and determine whether to appeal or seek further relief. Justice Baah J. A. explained that the position of law does, and I quote him,

“The plain meaning, scope, and effect of Rule 27.3(b) C.I. 19 is that, in respect of any ruling, judgement, or decision of the High Court of whatever description, in respect of which an appeal can be filed and further, in respect of which an application for a stay of execution or proceedings could be filed, there shall operate a statutory stay of execution or proceedings for a period of seven days. The apparent intent of the law is to enable the vanquished to ponder over and scrutinise the *bona fides* of the ruling, decision, or judgement in order to decide on whether or not to appeal. It is when a decision is made to appeal that an application may be made to the High Court under Rule 27.1(a) of C.I. 19 or to this Court under Rule 27.1(b) C.I. 19.”

In this instance, the ruling of the Tamale High Court was delivered on 24th

November, 2025. The statutory seven-day stay, therefore, remains in force until 1st December 2025. During this period, the ruling of the High Court cannot form the basis for the Speaker to instruct the Clerk to Parliament to notify the Electoral Commission that the Kpandai seat is vacant.

In addition to the above, should Mr Nyindam exercise his right of appeal, such as an application under Rule 27.1(b) of C.I. 19, it may impose a further suspension on the enforcement of the judgement until the application is determined by the appropriate Court. This rule appears to prevent the subject matter of the appeal from being altered or prejudiced while the appeal processes are pending.

Therefore, before the initial seven-day statutory stay, the filing of a stay application may yet introduce an additional layer that may prevent changes to the status of the Hon Member within the meaning of Articles 97 and 99 of the Constitution. The attention of the House is also brought to Article 105 of the 1992 Constitution, which provides that a person who sits or votes in Parliament, “knowing or having reasonable grounds for knowing” that he is not entitled to do so commits an offence. It is crucial to emphasise that Article 105 is penal in nature, should the Hon Member know that he ought not to be in the Chamber and he participates in the activities in the Chamber.

Hon Members, it is therefore premature to say that Mr Matthew Nyindam is disqualified from entering

and participating in the proceedings of the House, because this period still falls within the seven-day mandatory stay of execution of the Order.

Hon Members, this is not a declaratory order. It is an executive order that was delivered by the High Court, and so the Hon Member is right to have been in the House yesterday and to have participated in the proceedings. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Ruling with Respect to the Complaint of Contempt against Hon Alexander Afenyo-Markin

Hon Members, as I indicated, I had a second job to do, and that had to do with the ruling. The ruling is in respect of the complaint of contempt that was brought against the Hon Minority Leader, Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin, Member of Parliament (MP) for Effutu and Minority Leader of the House.

Hon Members, on Tuesday, 11th November, 2025, this House received a formal complaint under Orders 6 and 33 from Mr Mahama Ayariga, MP for Bawku Central and Majority Leader. The complaint alleges that Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin, MP for Effutu and Minority Leader, has engaged in conduct which, if substantiated, may constitute contempt of Parliament and a breach of Parliamentary privilege, pursuant to Orders 30 and 31(o) of our Standing Orders. The complaint arises from events said to have occurred during the sitting of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) Parliament in Port Harcourt, River State,

Nigeria, from 25th to 28th September, 2025.

According to Mr Ayariga, Mr Afenyo-Markin attended that session of the ECOWAS Parliament in contravention of a duly adopted Resolution of this House, which excluded his name from Ghana's delegation to that Regional Parliament. The complainant asserts further that this conduct amounts to an affront to the authority and dignity of Parliament and accordingly invites the Speaker to refer the matter to the Committee on Privileges and Immunities for enquiry and recommendations to the House.

1:32 p.m.

Hon Members, as I indicated at the close of the Majority Leader's submission that day, the Standing Orders prescribed the procedure to be followed when allegations of contempt or breach of privilege are raised. It falls to the Speaker, in the first instance, to determine whether the facts disclosed in the complaint established a *prima facie* case, warranting referral to the Committee. Hon Members would recall that I deferred my ruling to the next day, and that was to be Wednesday, 12th November, 2025. However, the pressures of Business on the Order Paper made it impossible to deliver the ruling on that day. I am now in a position to do so.

In considering this matter, I have reflected carefully on the facts alleged, the Standing Orders and the relevant constitutional and statutory provisions

governing: (1) the authority of Parliament; (2) the binding force of Parliamentary resolutions, and (3) the scope of Parliament's contempt jurisdiction.

What is the nature and effect of a resolution of Parliament? Hon Members, a Resolution of Parliament is a formal act through which the House expresses its collective will on a matter properly before it. Once adopted, a Resolution becomes a binding decision of the House until it is rescinded, suspended, or varied in accordance with the Standing Orders of the House.

A Resolution, therefore, has continuing effects, and the Speaker, as the presiding authority, is bound to give effect to it. While the Speaker may clarify the scope or meaning of a Resolution, he cannot amend, modify, or disregard it unilaterally. Hon Members, this principle reflects the doctrine of collective responsibility. When Parliament speaks through a Resolution, that decision binds all Members, irrespective of political affiliation, leadership status, or personal opinion.

As Erskine May reminds us, and I quote Erskine May,

“The dignity of Parliament depends upon the observation of its rules, and the authority of Parliament depends upon their enforcement.”

This is the foundation upon which Parliamentary collective responsibility rests.

So, what is the power and scope of Parliament's contempt jurisdiction? Contempt of Parliament refers to any act or omission that obstructs, impedes, or undermines Parliament in the performance of its functions, or which affronts its dignity, or tends either directly or indirectly to obstruct, impede, and undermine Parliament in the performance of its functions, or affronts the dignity of Parliament. Parliament's power to address contempt is inherent in its constitutional status as a coordinate arm of Government, and is expressly recognised under article 122 of the 1992 Constitution, Order 30 of the Standing Orders, and Section 26 of the Parliament Act, 1965, (Act 300).

Hon Members, the jurisdiction to sanction contempt is not limited to acts committed within the Chamber. The relevant test is whether the conduct, wherever it occurs, has a direct or indirect tendency to obstruct, diminish, or bring Parliament into disrepute or ridicule. Parliament may therefore exercise its contempt jurisdiction over conducts occurring outside the precincts of the House, where such conduct undermines the institution's authority or impairs its ability to give effect to its decisions.

Hon Members, I note that the specific instances of contempt listed in the Standing Orders, such as disorderly behaviour, deceit, or disobedience of an Order issued by the Presiding Officer, do not expressly identify non-compliance with or disregard of a Resolution as a distinct ground of contempt.

A Resolution, as earlier observed, is a decision of Parliament, not an order of the Speaker. There is therefore no express provision making its breach a stand-alone category of contempt. However, Section 26 of Act 300 makes clear that the enumeration of contempt grounds is not exhaustive. Parliament retains the right to treat as contempt any act that impedes its functions or affronts its dignity. Order 31(o) similarly contemplates conduct, whether specific or general, that brings Parliament into disrepute or undermines its institutional authority. It is within this broader category that the present allegation must be assessed.

Hon Members, it is useful to consider what constitutes an affront to the dignity or authority of Parliament. Orders 30(c) and 31(o) prove directly or indirectly bring Parliament into disrepute or undermine its authority, reputation, or dignity may amount to contempt. These capture behaviours that, while not obstructing proceedings, undermines Parliament's standing, coherence, or credibility. An affront to the dignity or authority of Parliament may arise where a Member's conduct: (a) challenges or disregards a valid act or decision of the House; (b) diminishes the institutional authority of Parliament or the Speaker; (c) undermines public confidence in the discipline, unity, or dignity of Parliament; or (d) brings Parliament into disrepute before State organs or external bodies.

Unlike other specific grounds of contempt set out in the Standing Orders, this category focuses not on the place

where the act occurred, but on its effect. Conduct that conveys the impression that Parliament's decision may be ignored without consequence qualifies as an affront to dignity, even if committed outside the precincts of the House.

Democratic experience across the world teaches that institutions endure not by their formal design alone, but by the conduct of those entrusted with them. The strength of this House, therefore, rests not merely in its constitutional design, but in the consistent respect Members accord to its decisions and processes.

Hon Members, having reviewed the complaints, the Standing Orders, and the Governing Principles, I am satisfied that the matter raised *prima facie* implicates the dignity and institutional integrity of this House. Pursuant to Order 34(1), I therefore refer the matter, the complaints lodged by the Hon Member for Bawku Central and Majority Leader to the Committee on Privileges and Immunities, for examination, enquiry, investigation, and report to the House. The Committee is directed to (1) ascertain the relevant facts giving rise to the Complaints, including the actions taken by the House and by the Hon Member concerned; (2) Review those actions taken within the framework of the Outstanding Orders and the applicable protocols of the ECOWAS Parliament; (3) Determine whether the conduct, if established, constitutes contempt of Parliament or a breach of privilege under Orders 30 and 31(o); and (4) Make appropriate recommendations to the House for its consideration.

1:42 p.m.

In conclusion, Hon Members, whatever our political differences, the authority of Parliament rests on a shared commitment to respect its decisions and uphold the integrity of its processes. Allegations that a Member has disregarded a decision of this House must therefore be examined with fairness, constitutional fidelity and a clear regard for the institutional independence of Parliament.

I urge the Committee to discharge its mandate with diligence, impartiality and decorum, ensuring that all parties are given a fair hearing. Until the Committee completes its enquiry and reports to the House, I advise Hon Members to refrain from public commentary on this matter in order to preserve the dignity and unity of this august House.

I thank all of you for your attention and I pray that discipline will prevail in this matter. Thank you so much.

Hon Members, we now take the item numbered 5 on the *Order Paper*, *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT

The Speaker: Hon Members, we start with the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 26th November 2025.

Page 1...8—

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I was on my feet at page 7. The item numbered 5 (d) on page 7, I humbly propose that we insert the word “of” after pupils so that it stands as “staff and pupils of”. What I have here does not have it.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Table, take note of that. That is page 8 not 7.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr George Kwame Aboagye: Mr Speaker, yesterday I was present but I have been marked absent on page 1. My name is supposed to be on page 1 but I have seen it at page 7, the absentees’ page.

The Speaker: What is your name?

Mr Aboagye: Aboagye, George Kwame.

The Speaker: Aboagye, George Kwame, Asene/Manso/Akroso Constituency?

Mr Aboagye: Yes, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: You see, when we were at page 1, you were absent.

Mr Aboagye: No, Mr Speaker, I was present.

The Speaker: So how come you did not see it?

Mr Aboagye: I just saw it.

The Speaker: Table, kindly cross-check your records and if what he says is true, capture him as present.

Page 9—

Yes, Hon Member, is it on page 8?

Mr Dickson Kyere-Duah: Page 7, the item numbered 11, Dickson Kyere-Duah, Mr Speaker. I have inadvertently been added to the list of those who were absent yesterday. But I was conspicuously here from the beginning to the end yesterday.

The Speaker: How do you know it was inadvertence?

Mr Kyere-Duah: Because I was here from beginning to the end, so I assume it was a mistake.

The Speaker: So, if the records do not show that you were here. **[An Hon Member:** He is always punctual] He is always punctual? You are getting some false witnesses. *[Laughter]*

Mr Kyere-Duah: Mr Speaker, I have always been very punctual and diligent in this House.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, but today, for example, you were not punctual, so if they say you are always punctual—I sit here, I count the numbers and then I take time for you to show up before I start even opening Prayer. So, I know those who are punctual and those

who are not punctual. Today, you were not punctual.

Mr Kyere-Duah: Mr Speaker, I was here until 12:30 p.m., when proceedings were not starting, I ran to the Committee hearing of the Budget Estimate of the Ministry of Sports and Recreation. So, Mr Speaker, I have always been very punctual, except that when you came in, I had dashed to the Committee hearing, but when I saw you were in, I rushed back.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Well, you do not know the time we started today.

Mr Kyere-Duah: Yes, Mr Speaker, I was monitoring. So, the moment you came in, I—

The Speaker: The question is, you do not know the time we started today.

Mr Kyere-Duah: At the time of saying the Prayer, I was in, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: I said, you do not know the time we started today.

Mr Kyere-Duah: Mr Speaker, no, I did not check.

The Speaker: That is sufficient. Table Office, please cross-check your records and do the right thing.

Mr Kyere-Duah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Page 10—

1:52 p.m.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, with respect, I think I have an observation on page 9, the item numbered 10, the last but one line. If we could insert “Speaker” after “Hon Second Deputy”.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Table Office, the part in italics, insert “Speaker” after “Deputy”.

Page 10...12?

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of the 22nd Sitting dated Wednesday, 26th November, 2025, as corrected, is adopted as a true record of proceedings.

The Speaker: Are we ready for Urgent Questions?

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Kwami Etse Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, that is so. The Hon Minister for Education is here.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we take the item numbered 6, Urgent Questions.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the further arrangement is that we will limit the— we are praying you to limit the supplementary questions to one, so we can have enough time to take a lot of the Questions.

The Speaker: Hon Members, before I go on, let me acknowledge the presence of some schools. *[Pause]*

Hon Members, let us go on with the Urgent Questions while some things are sorted out. Let us take item numbered 6 (a). The Urgent Question stands in the name of Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah, Member of Parliament for Okaikwei Central.

Hon Member, you may ask your Question.

URGENT QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF EDUCATION

Measures to Finance the Upcoming End-of-Academic-Year Examination

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (NPP — Okaikwei Central): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Education what measures the Ministry is implementing to finance the upcoming end-of-academic-year examination in public basic schools and prevent the charging of exam fees.

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, let me thank you for the opportunity to respond to the question on the financing of end-of-academic-year exams and preventing charging of exam fees by persons, as was asked by Mr Patrick Boamah.

Mr Speaker, to put it in context, examination is an assessment and is

within the remit of the West African Examination Council (WAEC). We recognise the right of every child and person to have the right to equal educational opportunities and facilities, and with a view to achieving the full realisation of that right, we are reminded that basic education remains free, compulsory and available to all. It is regrettable that since the implementation of the 1992 Constitution, 30 years on, Ghana has not been able to attain free, compulsory, universal basic education. We would need the support of this House to ensure that every Ghanaian child gets educated so that our national literacy rates can improve.

Korea, today, boasts a national literacy rate of 98 per cent, while Ghana is still around 78 per cent, with wide disparities. Mr Speaker, the Government pays this through the Capitation Grant, which is used as a key instrument to actualise Article 25(1) of the 1992 Constitution. GH¢72,765,850 have so far been disbursed as Capitation Grants for 2024/2025, benefiting some 6,154,953 learners across the country.

Mr Speaker, the Capitation Grant for the first term of 2025/2026 has been processed for release.

Measures to address unauthorised charging of fees

The Director General of the Ghana Education Service (GES) have issued a directive banning all side charges. And circulars have been sent, and regular reminders have been sent to all GES institutions. The Ministry of Education

and GES has deployed monitoring teams for audit, inspection and randomised spot checks. GES has established reporting timelines and other mechanisms, including Parent-Teacher Association (PTA) meetings and suggestion boxes.

The Ministry remains committed to eliminating financial barriers at the basic level of education. So there is no problem with it. Capitation Grants have been paid, and it covers examination fees. So, no parent or child is required to pay for any examination fee. If any head teacher or teacher is caught, they will be sanctioned in accordance with the GES standards.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: I am told the agreement is one supplementary question, so you can do so.

Mr Boamah: Mr Speaker, I do not have any supplementary questions. I thank the Minister for answering my Question.

The Speaker: We now take item numbered 6(b), which stands in the name of Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam, Hon Member for Pru East.

Hon Member, you may do so now.

Measures to Prevent Examination Malpractice and Cancellation of Examination Papers

Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (NDC — Pru East): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Education measures the

Ministry has implemented to prevent examination malpractices and cancellation of examination papers, especially in Basic Education Certificate Examination (BECE) and West African Senior School Certificate Examination (WASSCE), considering the negative impact such cancellation has had on students of my Constituency in the previous years. Thank you.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the West African Exams Council is mandated to conduct credible, world-class examinations and protect the integrity of exams to ensure educational quality, national development, and every child has the right to a fair, trustworthy assessment process. Cancellation occurs only after thorough investigation showing concrete evidence of collusion, foreign materials, impersonation, and the use of electronic devices.

2:02 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the West African Examination Council is working with the GES through public sensitisation, randomisation of test papers, enhanced security at the printing press, stronger collaboration with law enforcement for arrest and prosecution, and increased deployment of trained supervisors. There is a growing phenomenon of phone-related exam malpractice, where learners smuggle phones into the examination room, and that is quite troubling and it undermines the integrity of our exams. Mr Speaker, integrity is the hallmark of the moulding of character with discipline.

Mr Speaker, any time such an incident occurs, the West Africa Examination Council will normally put their school on notice that they are investigating a certain unacceptable conduct. Where they finish their investigation, and there is evidence to support it, they will proceed to sanction. So, there are many areas where the West Africa Examination Council will decide that a particular town or school is not fit for purpose for the conduct of the exam arising out of misconduct by students or teachers or in collusion with both.

The Government and the assessment institution take a serious view of it. What we need to do is to grow our learners with integrity. Mr Speaker, we are currently revising the curriculum for kindergarten to primary six, and we are incorporating integrity and ethics into the training of young Ghanaians so that they know their values of patriotism, responsibility, and integrity.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Hon Members, First Deputy Speaker to take the chair.

2:03 p.m. —

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any supplementary question?

Mr Boam: Yes, Mr Speaker.

From the response of the Minister, it is certain that a lot of these practices are related to mobile phones. It would interest us to know that the Bono Region and Ahafo Region, between 2021 and 2024, happen to be the highest of all the malpractices.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, ask a supplementary question

Mr Boam: I want to find out from the Minister if there is any specific intervention for these regions, as most of them are affected.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Ministry does not interfere with the work of the West African Examination Council. As I stated, it is an assessment institution that is independent and autonomous. They are expected to uphold the highest level of integrity and ensure that they safeguard it.

But, Mr Speaker, as I indicated, normally, after the conduct of exams through marking, they would alert the institutions that we are investigating some behaviour or conduct. When they are satisfied that that behaviour may have resulted in an examination malpractice, they will proceed to sanction the institution. Mr Speaker, I currently have a proposal in my office that we should deploy Close Circuit Television (CCTV) cameras at the examination centres. We are looking at the cost of it and our capacity to be able

to do that. However, what is important is that learners must grow and learn with hard work and with integrity. I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further supplementary?

Mr Boam: Mr Speaker, I am alright.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Yes?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we agreed at Conclave that a sponsor of a Question will have only a supplementary, so we can have enough time to take the rest.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Mr Kyei Asamoah?

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Mr Speaker, I thank the Minister for his Response to the exam malpractices. I want to know from the Hon Minister, to improve on this, how is the Ministry working to collaborate with West African Examination Council (WAEC), so that we can also introduce the serialisation and digitisation of our exams, to help curb this examination malpractice?

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, Ghana is going digital with its Free Senior High School initiative. I inherited a contract with about US\$337 million, where some 1.3 million tablets were to be distributed across the country to all Free Senior High Schools, so that

learners can have access to digital tools. I am told that deployment of the tablets is around 980,000. Through GETFund, we are supporting the distribution across the country. However, this morning, my attention was drawn to the fact that many of the devices are not customised, and the students are using it for other purposes, including pornography, which is not acceptable. Therefore, Government is taking a review of it. There must be restrictions as to what the tablets can be used for, and it should be used strictly for purpose of study.

Mr Speaker, the curriculum is offloaded onto the tablet. It will facilitate digital learning. We are to be reminded that when we are training students, we are training them to be globally competitive. Therefore, we have to take investment in digital skills and digital technology, and its deployment much more seriously with increased investment. I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Minister. Can we move to Question numbered 6(c), standing in the name of Hon Charles Forson, Member of Parliament for Tema Central?

Mr Charles Forson (NPP — Tema Central): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Education the steps the Ministry is taking to curb the use of fake education credentials such as PhD among others?

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC) is mandated by Section 840 of

the Education Regulatory Bodies Act 2020 (Act 1023), to regulate the use of higher education nomenclature and titles, including Emeritus Professors, Doctors, Chartered and related terms. Act 1023 also mandates the Commission to verify the authenticity of all certificates, diplomas, and degrees upon request.

Thus, within the intent of the Act, the Commission has initiated the following to curb the use of fake educational credentials. Evaluating and authenticating of credentials awarded by local and foreign institutions accredited by the Commission, the Commission has issued a press statement warning the public against the use of the fake credentials. Following the above, persons who are believed to have publicly displayed fake credentials or credentials they are not entitled to are called out to demonstrate the authenticity of their credentials. Also, the public is called upon to refer doubtful qualifications to the Commission for evaluation and for action.

But, Mr Speaker, if Professor Azumah Nelson earned his professor by way of boxing and then informally you want to say that you are taking his professor title from boxing, who judges that, Mr Speaker? I leave it to the public.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Any supplementary?

Mr Forson: Thank you, Hon Minister. I further wish to ask— We should take certain steps to cure that. This is because we have situations where

persons with fake, certificates come into the House and other—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But the Question is on steps taken.

Mr Forson: Yes, I am following up, respectfully, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, what is the question?

Mr Charles Forson: Mr Speaker, how is the Ministry supporting GTEC? GTEC only names a shame. We need to—There should be certain punitive actions which will serve as deterrent. That is what I am asking the Minister.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, Hon Minister, you have the floor.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, as a Minister, mine has to do with is policy. I do not interfere with the regulatory mandate or authority of any institution. GTEC has every power and option to take legal action where necessary. The Director-General is doing his utmost best and he has the support of the law.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You have heard the agreement that one supplementary Question.

We will move to Oral Questions, the Question numbered 179, standing in the name of Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie, Member of Parliament for Odododiodioo Constituency.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF EDUCATION

Update on Stalled Sempe School Project in Odododiodioo

Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (NDC — Odododiodioo): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Education an update on the stalled Sempe School project in Odododiodioo and the reasons for the delay.

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, the Accra Sempe Basic School is located in the Ashiedu Keteke Sub-Metro of the Greater Accra Region. The school, currently occupying a temporal structure on the premises of the Freeman Methodist Church has a total enrolment of 454 learners, comprising 235 boys and 219 girls and a staff strength of 20.

The condition of the school deteriorated significantly, resulting in learners undertaking teaching and learning activities in temporary structures. As a result of this, Accra Metropolitan Assembly (AMA) deemed it necessary to initiate the construction of a three-storey 18-Unit Classroom Block to address the growing school-age population in the Constituency and to improve educational infrastructure. This intervention was undertaken to replace the deteriorated facilities, ensure a safe learning environment for the pupils, and respond to the increasing enrolment within the Constituency.

Mr Speaker, the construction of the three-storey, 18-Unit Classroom Block is not a GETFund funded project. However, the Ministry has assessed the situation and would engage the Accra Metropolitan Assembly and GETFund to ensure the completion of the project to accommodate the growing population of children of school going age within the Constituency.

Mr Speaker, currently, there are about 5,000 schools still under trees in the country. We need to increase our investment in basic education, particularly in foundational learning. If the child gets it right at age six, the child is likely to get it right at age 80. Therefore, it is a policy decision of Government to increase investment in basic education.

Accordingly, as was announced by the Hon Minister for Finance, a number of basic school infrastructure, including 200 Junior High Schools will be built across the country in a number of primary schools.

I thank you.

2:12 p.m.

Mr Ashie: Mr Speaker, I have confidence in the Minister's intervention, so I will end it here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. This is a constituency-specific Question. We will move to the Question numbered 218, standing in the name of Dr Fred

Kyei Asamoah, Member of Parliament for Offinso North. You have the floor.

Payment of 2025 Book and Research Allowance to Teacher Unions

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I beg to ask the Minister for Education the steps being implemented to ensure prompt payment of the 2025 Book and Research Allowance to members of the Teacher Unions.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Book and Research Allowance was introduced in Public Universities with its intended purpose of helping lecturers acquire academic materials and carry out research. The Allowance which seeks to equip lecturers to perform scholarly work, also serves as a statutory entitlement and essential resource for advancing research, teaching, and knowledge sharing.

The Ministry, in collaboration with the Ministry of Finance and the Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC), has instituted clear measures to ensure the prompt payment of the allowance to eligible members of the teacher unions in public tertiary institutions.

Mr Speaker, a total amount of GH¢610million has been released and disbursed as Book and Research Allowance for the 2024/2025 academic year.

The Ministry remains committed to strengthening the research environment within tertiary institutions, the welfare of lecturers and the advancement of higher education in the country. The Ministry will work closely with all relevant stakeholders to sustain the smooth administration of the allowance and to promote quality teaching, research, and innovation at the tertiary education level.

Mr Speaker, last year, the burden of Government on Book and Research Allowance was in the region of some GH¢260 million. This year it has ballooned to GH¢610 million. Two days ago, I met with the Colleges of Education Teachers Association of Ghana (CETAG), the striking workers of the colleges of education, and I persuaded them to call off their strike and give Government some two weeks to respond to their demand. It is only a matter of evaluating technically whether they deserve it or not.

But, Mr Speaker, one of the important issues which emerged in our meeting is that as part of their conditions of service, if the requirement is to have a Master of Philosophy degree (MPhil), and a person has a Master of Arts (MA), and the person agrees with GTEC that the standard is MPhil, Government, apart from the transitional period, will work to what has been agreed by the parties. This includes that if the requirement is that have an MPhil, it should be an MPhil. But they have a transition period for those with MA who have served in those institutions.

They are tertiary, so Government will support them with infrastructure. A number of them are complaining about vehicles. Some of them are using vehicles as old as 18 years, and that endangers their life. Mr Speaker, Government will see what it can do. So, Book and Research Allowance have been processed for university lecturers. Normally, it is a computation of the exchange rate, which is the determination of the Hon Minister for Finance.

I have called on CETAG to call off their strike, because in the event that we pay them, we cannot compensate for the time period lost while they were not in class, and they must deal with Government in good faith. But, Mr Speaker, it is important to add that these outstanding allowances date back to 2022.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Dr Asamoah: A copy of a letter available to me from the University Teachers' Association of Ghana (UTAG), that was in October, definitely had the notice of industrial action as a result of this Book and Research Allowance. In July this year, I had put in this Question.

So, Mr Speaker, my follow-up question to the Hon Minister is what other measures is he putting in place to reduce the waiting time and the anxiety that boils up with our teacher unions, so we can improve on our educational system?

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Ministry and Government remain committed to strengthening the research environment in our public tertiary institutions, and we are concerned and working to improve their welfare and conditions of service in order to advance higher education. Our core policy as Government is to emphasise access, relevance, and quality at the higher education level, and, Mr Speaker, our stakeholders will need to engage more on how to address to improve the quality of teaching, research and innovation in our public universities.

As we may recall, the President promised to establish the National Research Fund. That has been established, a board has been constituted, a chief executive appointed, the President will launch it early next year, and it will be given adequate resources to support research within the public universities.

Mr Speaker, last year, to support research in the public universities, we incorporated in the GETFund formula five locally sponsored scholarships to be paid for by GETFund, for any institution that wants to strengthen its faculty to take advantage of it, instead of wanting to travel abroad. It is still available, and interested applicants may go through the Ghana Tertiary Education Commission and their institutions. I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 219, standing in the name of Hon Collins Adomako Mensah, Member

of Parliament for Afigya Kwabre North Constituency. You have the floor.

Completion of GETFund-Sponsored Classroom Block at St Michael's S.H.S, Ahenkro

Mr Collins Adomako-Mensah (NPP — Afigya Kwabre North): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I beg to ask the Minister for Education when the GETFund-sponsored classroom block at St Michael's Senior High School at Ahenkro will be completed.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, St Michael's Senior High School is located in the Afigya Kwabre North District of the Ashanti Region. The school has an enrolment of 840 learners comprising of 562 boarders and 278 day students. There is currently one GETFund project ongoing in the school, that is, the Construction of a 12-unit classroom block.

The project was awarded to Messrs Banjesolex Company Limited on 5th November, 2018 at a contract sum of GH¢1,257,364.90 and being supervised by Messrs Amagalmated Grup. Works on the project stands at 70 per cent completion.

Mr Speaker, this project is part of the several uncompleted GETFund projects across the country due to funding challenges. The Ministry is committed to completing ongoing projects. Accordingly, the GETFund Formula provides for an allocation for ongoing projects.

GETFund currently is burdened because it is providing for free senior high school. Feeding alone stands around GH¢3 billion to GH¢4 billion. Some additional expenditure, I am informed, may dilute the GETFund and make it unable to undertake its traditional role and mandate of providing for infrastructure at all levels of education, particularly at the higher education level.

But, Mr Speaker, in the 2026 Budget, the Hon Minister for Finance announced the completion of a number of GETFund projects. Out of 52, some 22 have been selected for completion, and I will pay particular attention to my good Friend's constituency's uncompleted project.

Mr Speaker, the other difficulty is that if we awarded a contract in 2018 at GH¢1.2 million, we do not expect the contractor to finish it at the same rate, given that some time period has been lost, costs have risen, and the value of the contract may be more expensive for the contractor and that becomes a disincentive. Mr Speaker, Government is working to convert about 30 Category C schools to B, and about 10 to 20 Category B schools to C, and then expand infrastructure in the Category A schools.

Mr Speaker, I am told that if we go to Presbyterian Boys' Senior High School (PRESEC), the old boys who are here are aware that they even have to go to assembly in batches. Mfantipim School was in my office this morning to announce their 155th anniversary and to invite H.E President Mahama to be associated with it. We are building a

5,000-capacity assembly hall for a number of selected schools. The GETFund is providing US\$180 million to support our Secondary Education Learning Improvement Programme, which will focus on their completion.

Mr Speaker, on this question of placement, we heard all the conflict about Category A and Category B schools. Category A school simply means schools that are oversubscribed because of their quality or standing. We can build the infrastructure and support them with quality improvement. Mr Speaker, with some regret, I know that in the whole North East Region, there is no single Category A school. In the whole of the Savannah Region, there is no single Category A school. Oti Region has no Category A school. Yet, all these learners are to compete with the likes of their colleagues in Mfantipim School, Adisadel College and Wesley Girls' Senior High School.

2:22 p.m.

We need to respond to the equity challenge and ensure that through expanded infrastructure, both dormitories and classrooms—

Mr Speaker, what happened significantly between 2018 and yesterday was that, we did not define what the word “free” is, in the transformative initiative for free senior high school. What is free? It is just about feeding? The President has directed that we should build large day schools in urban areas, like the Kwabenya type of school in Kasoa, Nima, Ayawaso or the

Bubuashie area, where we can do that kind of thing.

Mr Speaker, if we do not deboardinise—but we also know that in some rural areas, we necessarily must allow for boarding schools. There are about 46 applications in my office from Members of Parliament, seeking to convert day schools to boarding school. It comes at a cost.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund), as I have said, hitherto, was funded from Petroleum Revenue Management between 2018 and 2024. It is now being solely borne by the GETFund. That does not give the GETFund enough room to be able to do more for tertiary education, secondary and basic education.

I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member.

Mr Adomako-Mensah: No, I have not supplementary question. I just want to thank him for the assurance.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, we then move to the Question numbered 220. Standing in the name of Mr Elvis Osei Mensah-Dapaah, Member of Parliament for Ahafo Ano South West Constituency.

Refusal to Commission Mankranso Methodist KG Block

Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah (NPP — Ahafo Ano South West): Mr Speaker, thank you.

I rise to ask the Minister for Education about the stance of the Ministry on the refusal of the Chairman of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) in the Ahafo Ano South West Constituency to commission a safe and prepared educational facility (Mankranso Methodist KG Block) as well as the suitable interventions being implemented to ensure that the school children are not further deprived.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I would be happy to go with my Colleague, Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah at a convenient date in December to commission the facility for him—*[Hear! Hear!]* The office of the Minister goes beyond the watershed of partisanship. The facility is a state property invested with taxpayers' money. Every Ghanaian is entitled to the full benefits of their rights and benefits guaranteed under the 1992 Constitution.

Therefore, it is not the case that the chairman of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) in Ahafo Ano South—He probably was just supervising it. Once it is completed, it becomes a Ghana Education Service (GES) and a Government property. I am free after 4th December, 2025, so the Hon Member should give me a date. I probably may be in the Region from 12th to 20th December,

bearing my role in Parliament. I would happy to commission it.

Mr Speaker, I had the same reason given about a facility funded by the Ghana National Petroleum Commission (GNPC) Foundation at the Bimbilla Senior High School, Bimbilla which I commissioned two weeks ago when I was in Bimbilla. I heard the same political undertones as part of the reasons the commissioning delayed.

No, I was on my way to Bimbilla to commission it when my attention was drawn that the GNPC Foundation, which funded the project, was not invited to the project. I thought that was not good enough and therefore I deferred it. So, I would be happy to go and commission it for you. The Hon Member should not be too worried and concerned about any Chairman standing in his way.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, let me commend the Minister for Education for his assurance to the Hon Member.

The Hon Member has personally complained to me and I had cautioned that he should reach out to the Hon Minister. The Minister is the type of person who will not introduce partisanship as far as our educational facility building is concerned.

I want to urge the Minister to honour his words and ensure that this matter is resolved as soon as possible for it not to degenerate into unnecessary partisanship. I know he is a man of honour.

I want to assure the Minister that we on this Side of the House would cooperate with him, to ensure that he does what he has just put on record. I do not know if the Hon Member has a follow up question. But he is a very friendly person who is available to travel with you to the Consistency to get this matter resolved as soon as possible.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do you have a follow-up question?

Mr Osei Mensah: I just want to thank the Hon Minister for his assurance.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister for Education, on behalf of the House, I thank you very much for attending upon the House to respond to the Questions slated for you.

You are hereby discharged.

Yes, Hon Members, for now, by consensus, this brings us to the end of Question time. We would move straight to the item numbered 8.

Hon Members, we shall now conclude the commentary on the Statement made by the Hon Minister for Finance on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy

of Government of the Republic of Ghana for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Before calling on the Minority Leader, indulge me to announce the presence of our revered guests.

We have students from the Learning Center led by Emmanuel Dwuona-Okla, a teacher. They are from Tema Central Constituency; they are 43 in number.

We have TEIN UHAS, led by Nantaale Tarcisius, the President. They are from Hohoe and they are 18 in number. The Member of Parliament is there to attend to you.

[Pupils of the Learning Centre were acknowledged.]

[Students of TEIN UHAS were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I have the pleasure to introduce to you Hon Dr Sherif El Gabali, a Member of Parliament and the Chairman of the African Cooperation Committee of the Egyptian House of Representatives who is on a trade mission to Ghana. He is accompanied by H. E. Wael Fathy, the Egyptian Ambassador to Ghana. Ms Hania Elkady, Deputy Ambassador to Ghana and Ms Nesrine Weheesh, Head of Trade.

Hon Members, on your behalf, I wish them a pleasant stay in the country and a fruitful mission. They are, once again, very welcome. Thank you for coming.

Hon Members, on this note, I will give the floor to the Hon Minority Leader, Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin. You have the floor. You are speaking for one hour.

2:32 p.m.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of commentary from 26/11/2025]

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make comments for and on behalf of the Minority Caucus as we draw the curtains down on this important matter.

Mr Speaker, permit me to proceed my submissions with a quote from the Bible, the Book of Daniel, Chapter 6, verses 12 to 28;

“¹² So these men stormed in and found Daniel praying and pleading before his God. ¹³ Then they went to remind the king about the prohibition: “Did you not sign a decree, O king, that for thirty days, whoever makes a petition to anyone, divine or human, except to you, O king, shall be cast into a den of lions?”

The king answered them, “The decree is absolute, irrevocable under the law of the Medes and Persians.” ¹⁴ To this they replied, “Daniel, one of the Jewish exiles, has paid no attention to you, O king, or to the prohibition you signed;

three times a day he offers his prayer.”¹⁵ The king was deeply grieved at this news and he made up his mind to save Daniel; he worked till sunset to rescue him.¹⁶ But these men pressed the king. “Keep in mind, O king,” they said, “that under the law of the Medes and Persians every royal prohibition or decree is irrevocable.”¹⁷ So the king ordered Daniel to be brought and cast into the lions’ den. To Daniel he said, “Your God, whom you serve so constantly, must save you.”¹⁸ To forestall any tampering, the king sealed with his own ring and the rings of the lords the stone that had been brought to block the opening of the den.

¹⁹ Then the king returned to his palace for the night; he refused to eat and he dismissed the entertainers. Since sleep was impossible for him,²⁰ the king rose very early the next morning and hastened to the lions’ den.²¹ As he drew near, he cried out to Daniel sorrowfully, “Daniel, servant of the living God, has your God whom you serve so constantly been able to save you from the lions?”²² Daniel answered the king: “O king, live forever!²³ My God sent his angel and closed the lions’ mouths so that they have not hurt me. For I have been found innocent before him; neither have I done you any harm, O king!”²⁴ This gave the king great joy. At his order Daniel was brought up from the den; he was found to be unharmed because he trusted in his God.²⁵ The king then ordered the men who had accused Daniel, along with their children and their wives, to be cast into the lions’ den. Before they reached the bottom of the den, the lions overpowered them and crushed all their bones.

²⁶ Then King Darius wrote to the nations and peoples of every language, wherever they dwell on the earth: May your peace abound!²⁷ I decree that throughout my royal domain the God of Daniel is to be revered and feared:

“For he is the living God, enduring forever, whose kingdom shall not be destroyed, whose dominion shall be without end,²⁸ A saviour and deliverer, working signs and wonders in heaven and on earth, who delivered Daniel from the lions’ power.”

Mr Speaker, I proceed further with a quote from the 26th President of the United States of America, Theodore Roosevelt, on the 23rd April 1910. He addressed citizens of Paris on a speech titled, “Citizenship in a Republic” at Sorbonne in Paris.

Mr Speaker, this was during his post-presidential tour of Europe. In veritable words, he reminded the world of one enduring truth;

“It is not the critic who counts; not the man who points out how the strong man stumbles, or where the doer of deeds could have done them better. The credit belongs to the man who is actually in the arena, whose face is marred by dust and sweat and blood; who strives valiantly; who errs, who comes short again and again, because there is no effort without error and shortcoming; but who does actually strive to do the deeds; who knows great enthusiasms, the great devotions; who spends himself in a worthy cause; who at the best knows in

the end the triumph of high achievement, and who at the worst, if he fails, at least fails while daring greatly, so that his place shall never be with those cold and timid souls who neither know victory nor defeat.”

Mr Speaker, to this end, I want to urge my Colleagues in the Minority that although we walk through the valley of the shadow of death, we must fear no evil. Let us remain strong, refuse to be intimidated. Refuse the subtle culture of silence. Let us soldier on. Victory awaits us. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, the old wise saying reminds us that rising to eminence by merits, you live respected and die regretted. On this note, and with a heavy heart but clear duty, I come before you, Mr Speaker, having defended Budget Statements and Economic Policies in good times and reforms in difficult ones, I have stood on both Sides of this aisle. I have seen governments rise and fall and witnessed both the best of our democracy and sometimes its worst.

Mr Speaker, rarely have I encountered a Budget Statement and Economic Policy so detached from reality, so hollow in its promises, and so dangerous in its implications as the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy now before us. This is not a document of hope. It is not a blueprint for transformation. It is not even an honest accounting of our nation's condition. This Budget Statement and Economic Policy is built on propaganda, sustained by abandonment, and destined to deepen the suffering of ordinary Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, simply put, this is not a Budget Statement and Economic Policy. It is a national retreat disguised as a national plan. But this Government must keep in mind that it keeps repeating that it inherited a collapsed, comatose, lifeless economy in January 2025. But the World Bank, not the Minority, not the New Patriotic Party (NPP), but the World Bank, in its official Ghana review overview updated on October 6th, 2025, records the truth. I quote;

“Stabilisation has improved conditions with 2024 growth at 5.7%”

Mr Speaker, this must sink. 5.7 per cent real GDP growth in 2024, before this Government touched the wheel. Now compare that with your own projections. In their 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, they projected growth at 3.3 per cent, a collapse of 2.4 percentage points. Even the World Bank's generous assessment reaches only 4.3 per cent for 2025 and for 2026, this Budget Statement and Economic Policy promises 4.8 per cent. The arithmetic is brutal. The 2024 under Nana Akufo-Addo's NPP, 5.7 per cent growth, this has been certified by the World Bank. 2025 under the National Democratic Congress (NDC), 3.3 per cent to 4.3 per cent growth, according to their own figures. Then the 2026 under the same NDC, they project 4.8 per cent. If 5.7 per cent growth is comatose, what name should we give to 3.3 per cent? Paralysed or dead-on arrival?

By their own numbers, the economy is now performing worse than the so-called collapse they claimed they inherited; the

truth is merciless. The New Patriotic Party (NPP) handed over a stabilised, recovering economy growing at 5.7 per cent. The NDC slowed it by 3 to 4 per cent. When one slows down faster than the dead economy inherited, one cannot claim to have inherited ruins. This grand deception is a foundation of everything that follows.

2:42 p.m.

Mr Speaker, every abandoned programme, every misprioritised allocation and every constitutional violation, once this lie is exposed, everything else begins to crumble. It is the reason I reminded my Colleagues that if one rises to eminence by merit, one lives respected. Now their lies and propaganda stand exposed after they lied to the people.

Mr Speaker, let me turn to the human consequences of this deception. Six Ghanaian women died in a stampede at El-Wak Stadium. They were not there because they all dreamed of becoming soldiers. They were there because in an economy where jobs have vanished and opportunity has been strangled, any recruitment exercise looks like a lifeboat. Those young women died because desperation met with poor preparation in a context of mass joblessness. Their deaths are not random. They are a direct consequence of policy abandonment. They are the human cost of government that has slowed economic growth and quietly killed the very programmes that once absorbed labour and gave young people hope.

If the Planting for Food and Jobs (PFJ) Programme was still robust, if the One District, One Factory (1D1F) was still expanding, if the Agenda 111 project was employing workers across the country, the probability of thousands of desperate young women piling up at the gates would have been far lower. Before we discuss billions and percentages, let us remember that their deaths must not be in vain. Their budget must be judged by whether it prevents another El-Wak stadium tragedy or guarantees more. On that test, this Budget fails catastrophically. The El-Wak tragedy was not an isolated incident. It was a direct consequence of economic policy that has methodically dismantled every viable pathway to employment.

Mr Speaker, consider the evidence, where 32 per cent of youth aged 15 to 24 per cent are unemployed. These statistics reflect a challenge we inherited when we assumed office in 2017, yet we actively addressed these through structured programmes such as: the Planting for Food and Jobs (PFJ), 1D1F, Agenda 111 and the YouStart Entrepreneurial Funding and Training; while imperfect, these programmes constituted a functioning employment architecture that delivered 5.7 per cent economic growth.

The response of the Government was a systematic demolition. They eliminated their PFJ without replacement, 1D1F was cancelled, and they abandoned Agenda 111. What do we see? Stagnation. Having dismantled the working solution, they now offer an uncosted fantasy of 800,000 new jobs

and a betrayed manifesto promised. Where are the 1 million coders that have been reduced to 100 million without targets, alongside a declining growth to 3.3 per cent? Let me be blunt, their priorities are in the least a scandal. They can find billions for new presidential jets, yet find a fraction of that for their jobs for the youth. What matters more, is it the comfort of a new presidential jet or the survival of millions on the ground?

Mr Speaker, this is not just hypocrisy. It is a declaration of war on the aspiration of our children. The young women at El-Wal Stadium did not just die. They were sacrificed on the altar of political vanity and breathtaking incompetence; we will not stand for it. The youth of Ghana deserve better than ghost programmes and empty promises. They deserve the ladder of opportunity this Government so cruelly destroyed.

Mr Speaker, let me now turn to the Budget itself. This Budget is a “cut-and-paste” Budget. When we say the successes of the former President, Nana Addo’s government is as a result of solid foundation laid by his administration, the NDC starts to fight, but take a look at pages 74 to 76, paragraphs 519 to 533. It is a complete “cut-and-paste” Budget.

They claim we have a Ministry for Works and Housing, yet with all the 16 Ministers and with all the appointees in Cabinet, they could not open their eyes to see that they were selling something to Parliament that they themselves have not defined as part of the Ministries. How can they, at paragraph 519, claim that

there is a Ministry of Railway Development?

How can they, at paragraph 528, say that the Ministry of Sanitation and Water Resources, and then at paragraph 523, again say Ministry of Works and Housing? Where was the Hon Deputy Minister, who could have paid attention to these details and dotted the “Is”? Where were the Ministers? Yet this document has been brought to Parliament. In the least, this document must be withdrawn, and a new Budget brought before Parliament. Parliament will not accept this “cut-and-paste” budget. All the things they have in there are things they pulled from the previous budget and pasted. Where is the Ministry of Railway Development?

Mr Speaker, our Friends have been exposed. A lazy attitude in preparation of a national document for Parliament. How could it have been a mistake? This is not a mistake; this is incompetence. It is clear that they did not prepare the Budget with due diligence, else they would not have written the Ministry of Works and Housing, the Ministry of Railway Development, or written anything, because they think they have the numbers to say “*Hear!Hear!*”

We, the Minority, the mighty Minority, will scrutinise, and they can choose to use the courts and other means, together with their numbers, to get all of us out of this Chamber; we will still protest and scrutinise them outside of this Chamber.

Mr Speaker, at paragraph 33, page 5 of the Budget, this is what they say, and I read:

“Mr Speaker, the year 2025 has unfolded against a backdrop of deepening global uncertainty. Heightened trade disputes, persistent geopolitical tensions, and uneven monetary tightening across major economies have dampened global confidence and investment flows...”

Mr Speaker, these are the words of the Minister for Finance. Since when have global economic uncertainties affected the economy of Ghana?

Mr Speaker, when they were in opposition, they failed to accept that global economic challenges had effects on Ghana. Today, in presenting their national Budget, they are blaming global uncertainties as having affected them.

2:52 p.m.

Mr Speaker, our Friends have been exposed; their hypocrisy is now known to the people of Ghana, that this is not a group of principled political leaders, but a group of convenience political leaders. Each day in Government, they change their positions, they change authority as and when it pleases them. Mr Speaker, we would hold them to account, we would expose them, we would scrutinise every move of theirs. Even if they use subtle ways to reduce our numbers, and we are left with one in this Chamber, we would put the heat at their feet and make life uncomfortable for them.

Mr Speaker, today, if you read paragraph 902 all the way to 905, this Government claims that Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) would be drilling oil in 2026. Mr Speaker, a critical question must be asked whether or not GNPC can undertake major exploration, especially drilling in the Volta Basin, with such drastically reduced funding? Mr Speaker, they claim that we as a country we are going to generate our own power. This power that we are going to generate, have they first dealt with the inefficiencies in the system? Because currently there is excess capacity. The take-or-pay agreement we have is costing so much money. They have not dealt with it, and they say they are going to set up a new thermal plant by using future savings to do that. Is it another scandal in waiting?

Mr Speaker, if the Majority and its Government do not avail themselves for the Minority, as few as we are with our might and intellect to scrutinise them, they may go down in history as the most corrupt Government in the history of Ghana. They should avail themselves and let us scrutinise them. Mr Speaker, look at the ECOWAS sub-regional growth. On page 8, table 4 of the Budget, it clearly explains why the mighty Minority says that this Budget is growthless, jobless, and hopeless. Mr Speaker, perhaps—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, please proceed. The respective Backbenches should take note. I can hear noise from both Sides. So, we should all remain silent and listen to the debate. Please continue.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Thank you. Mr Speaker, the Ghanaian story, when compared to our peers in ECOWAS, is nothing good to write home about. From page 8, table 4 of their own Budget, it is clear that all other countries in the sub-region did so well in terms of their growth. Mr Speaker, if you walk through this list one by one, their incompetence is exposed. We are asking them, where are their jobs? Where is their 24-Hour Economy? It is clear that their 24-Hour Economy *ato nsuom*.

Mr Speaker, let us go to the industrial sector with reference to appendix 1(c) of page 15. The NPP administration left a burgeoning industry sector that grew at 7.1 per cent. Mr Speaker, growth in that sector has declined to a paltry 3.6 per cent in 2025. This decline is due to the lack of activity in the construction sub-sector. Numbers do not lie. Whereas the construction sub-sector grew at 9.6 per cent in 2024, growth in the sector has declined to 2.9 per cent in 2025.

Now, they see why we have been clamouring for them to pay contractors. Even their own Ministers, in 2025, did not have their releases. Non-payment of arrears owed contractors means they have to move away from sites. Most road projects initiated have been abandoned. Agenda 111 has been abandoned. Construction is the bedrock of the industrial sector. A lot of Ghanaians get their daily bread when construction booms.

They cannot profess a certain Big-Push agenda and not pay hard-working contractors. They cannot profess a Big-

Push agenda while projects started by the previous government are stalled.

Mr Speaker, the NDC administration must learn to pay contractors, continue road projects started by the NPP administration, continue the Agenda 111, continue the numerous projects in the educational sector, complete the bypass on the Acca-Kumasi Road, complete the Kasoa-Winneba Road, finish the Adenta-Dodowa Road, finish the Tema-Prampram stretch, complete the Suami Interchange, and finish the PTC Interchange. Mr Speaker, the NPP administration under Nana Akufo-Addo has a record of over 13,000 km of road. The 13,000-plus km road construction under the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo government can never be matched by this administration.

Mr Speaker, let us look at revenue, fiscal performance. May I refer them to Appendix 2(a) at page 154 of the 2026 Budget Statements and Economic Policy. In presenting the Budget in March 2025, the Minister projected total revenues and grants of GHC224.93 billion, representing 16.1 per cent of Gross Domestic Product (GDP). Mr Speaker, the Minority told the NDC to stop the voodoo forecasting because it was unachievable and that the figures were cooked to make their Budget look good. Mr Speaker, unperturbed, in the Mid-Year Budget review, they presented a further revised revenue and grants upwards to GHC229.9 billion, representing 16.4 per cent of GDP.

Again, we warned them to desist from deceiving the Ghanaian public and

potential investors. What do we see now? The Minister for Finance and his government have finally revised the end-year projected revenue and grant to GH¢226.4 billion, a whopping GH¢3.5 billion difference. Is this competence? Incompetence. Mr Speaker, the bizarre aspect of all of this is that they disregarded the full facts and figures. They programmed to rake in GH¢162.6 billion in the first nine months of the year, and this programming was done significantly in July.

3:02 p.m.

Mr Speaker, in the first nine months they were able to only get 11.1 per cent. What are they hiding from the Ghanaian people? How can they raise GH¢72 billion in three months when they only had GH¢154 billion in nine months? They can project big revenue but actual performance would expose them. I repeat, they can project big revenue but actual performance will expose them. A word to the wise is enough.

Now, Mr Speaker, let us look at expenditure. Expenditure at the Presidency has ballooned. It is in excess of GH¢1.5 billion. The Deputy Minister can shake his head but I wish he could state this for the record. Perhaps he does not know what is contained in the Budget. We the mighty Minority have read the Budget in full and we know the details. They failed to provide for the private sector. They failed to create opportunities yet at the Presidency alone they are spending in excess of GH¢1.5 billion.

Mr Speaker, let me turn to the women banking sector. I want to remind the NDC that they cannot deceive the Ghanaian people. I refer them to appendix 4A on page 174 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. They claim that they are providing GH¢401 million to start the Women's Development Bank. What they try to hide are the things I am going to tell the Ghanaian people. Per the Banks and Specialised Deposit Act, 2016 (Act 930), there is supposed to be a minimum capital which capital must be unimpaired.

Now, the minimum capital requirement for establishing a bank is GH¢400 million. That GH¢400 million you cannot touch it. So, if they say they are providing GH¢400 million to establish the Women's Development Bank, what money are they going to use to provide the loans? In the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, they did nothing about the Women's Development Banking. Now they are providing for GH¢400 million to establish a bank. What are they going to give out as loans? Again, they have deceived the women of this country. In 2025, they provided nothing, then in 2026 too, nothing.

Mr Speaker, the 24-Hour Economy has now become a chorus. If we go through paragraphs 431, 458, 479, of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, there is one chorus. They even describe it at 24-Hour Economy plus and 24-Hour Economy. Which is which? They precede every paragraph with 24-Hour Economy. So, what is the meaning of 24-

Hour Economy? The one job, three shifts *no wɔ he? Okɛɛ okɛ nitsumɔ baaba, ɲgbɛ nitsumɔ lɛ yɔɔ? Aabibo akɛɛ ɲgbɛ nitsumɔ lɛ yɔɔ?* The people of Ghana are asking the NDC, 2025, 2026—Even 2025, we can forgive them because they had just come. But what about 2026? What are the variables? What are the policy measures they have introduced to inspire growth, to create employment?

Mr Speaker, at Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG), even where they had an opportunity to use electricity tariffs as an incentive to develop this 24-Hour Economy, they failed. This year alone, they have increased tariffs by 18 per cent across the board. How do they, without introducing reforms, burden the ordinary Ghanaian to pay more taxes and more tariffs? Added to that was their GHC1 levy on petrol and diesel bought at the pump. What have they done? They claim that they are taking away E-levy, yet in the dead of night, they introduced the *dumsor* levy; they introduced 18 per cent increment on electricity tariffs; and in the same vein, they claim that they are going to provide an incentive for economic growth and for businesses to work all night. What hypocrisy. What a double standard. What an unprincipled government.

Mr Speaker, this Government claims that it is going to develop Ghana. I want to ask a simple question. What have they provided for agriculture? Go through the Budget on agriculture. They abandoned the planting for food and jobs; they are rather giving more money to the Gold Board and abandoning our farmers. Former President Akufo-Addo

constructed no less than 12 landing beach sites at our coast. Go to the fisheries sub-sector. What have they provided for them? Zero. Nothing. Yet, they say we should praise them. All the moneys they have provided for giving to activities through Gold Board, are they making a distinction between regularly mined gold and illicit gold? All we know is that Bank of Ghana is releasing dollars for Gold Board to buy gold. There is no transparent accounting system. But we tell them, one day, one day—**[Some Hon Members: One day, one day]**—all the transactions under Gold Board, where the exchange rate losses, the differentials, went to, they would account for them.

Mr Speaker, let me proceed to deal with another issue, public debts. Recently, the Vice President of our Republic raised this issue of public debts. Specifically, paragraph 199 to 201 at page 32, this is what the NDC said:

“The public debt to GDP declined from 68.9 per cent as of end of 2020, September 2024, to a 45 per cent a year later due to the Debt Exchange Programme.”

They go to the Ghanaian people and tell them that the Debt Exchange Programme was bad. But today, they are taking credit for the Debt Exchange Programme. They are telling the people of Ghana now, after they got power, that Domestic Debt Exchange Programme (DDEP) significantly lowered the debts. The agreement reached last year with commercial creditors, particularly euro bond holders, helped a lot in debt

reduction. The last leg with official bilateral creditors having become effective is a final bit. This is not prudent debt management, according to them. They are actually now adding to the debt stock. So, when they meet IMF and the World Bank, they praise the Akufo-Addo Administration for the steps taken in stabilising the economy. Yet, when they meet the full soldiers, they lie to them. They will be exposed. Their hypocrisy is now known to all. They are now known as a Government of convenience. Their principle is lost on them. Nobody takes them seriously.

Mr Speaker, let me refer to paragraph 364 at page 54 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. This is what the NDC Government says about the Electoral Commission:

“Mr Speaker, in 2025, the Electoral Commission delivered on its constitutional mandate with professionalism and transparency. Following the 2024 presidential and parliamentary elections, the Commission conducted elections for the confirmation of 261 metropolitan municipal district chief executives.

3:12 p.m.

It also organised rerun of the Ablekuma North parliamentary elections, conducted Akwatia by-elections and supervised the Council of State elections for 16 regional representatives.

Mr Speaker, today this same NDC is now crucifying the Electoral

Commission through a questionable petition. Again, the governance of convenience has been exposed. We thought that after coming to power and claiming that everything was in shambles, they would come up with a new idea.

Mr Speaker— *[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I intend not to interrupt, but you know the rules.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I will translate *[Uproar]*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please continue.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, Ghana— *[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*

One company, US\$10million. Meanwhile— *[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*

Mr Speaker, instead of granting a tax waiver to one company of US\$10.4 million, that money could have been used to construct more roads and schools, but they chose convenience.

[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]

Mr Speaker, agriculture has stopped absorbing labour, factories have stopped hiring, construction sites have shut down, young people are going somewhere, to many, they are going into illegal mining. Our rivers are turning

brown, our forests are disappearing, our cocoa farms are being destroyed, communities are being poisoned, and yet in this Budget Statement and Economic Policy, no bold, well-funded alternative livelihood programme is being initiated.

Mr Speaker, let me go to the GoldBod. This Government has surrendered to the *galamsey* activities. Let me even make it clear and graver, this Government has become its enabler. In this Budget, the Government has announced that GoldBod would purchase gold from small-scale miners. But recently, Professor Adei warned us that the GoldBod will become a state-launders mechanism for *galamsey* gold. They are not fighting illegal mining. The NDC Government, through GoldBod, is rather financing it. This is giving it state endorsement. So, all that they do, claiming that the National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS) is out there to enforce, is a falsehood.

Today, members of NAIMOS are getting hurt, shot at, and dying needlessly in a fight their own Government has abandoned. But let us remember, this is a country that lost eight innocent souls, including top two Ministers, on their way to a programme fighting illegal mining. Eight lives, two Ministers, all in

service of the fight against *galamsey*. And yet their own Government is, today, demonstrating neither the seriousness nor the commitment necessary to defeat illegal mining. Instead, it has set up a GoldBod to buy gold it cannot trace and

from miners it cannot verify. In a system designed for complicity rather than enforcement. This is horrifying.

This is a betrayal of those eight souls. It is a betrayal of every soldier risking their life. It is a betrayal of every Ghanaian who wants cleaner water and a future for their children. If this Government cannot trace the gold, it must not buy the gold.

Mr Speaker, let me now turn to their infamous sanitary pad scandal. Numbers do not lie. In July 2025, the Ministry of Finance said the price of sanitary pads had been reduced from GHC25 to 15. At that price, the 6.6 million they projected was supposed to cost GHC99 million. yet in the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, it states that the Ministry of Education had spent GHC45 per pad, totalling GHC292 million. So, how come the GHC15 per pad now rose to GHC45 per pad?

Mr Speaker, the gap between GHC292 million and GHC99 million is GHC193 million. This raises serious questions. This is a huge scandal with a large amount of GHC193 million ending up where?

3:22 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the NDC Government must come clean and explain this to the people of Ghana. We cannot sweep this under the carpet; we cannot be quiet; we will not be mute; they cannot shut us. They cannot use their numbers, and perhaps, if not satisfied, add a presiding officer to crush the Minority. We will be

loud, we will be clear, we will be bold and confront the misgovernance.

Mr Speaker, this 2026 Budget must be rejected, not out of spite, but out of duty; not to score points, but to defend the future; not to win an argument, but to prevent another El-Wak Sports Stadium stampede; and not in defiance of the Constitution, but to defend it. Our Friends appear clueless and appear not to understand the very mandate that has been given them by the people of Ghana. Every single thing they say, they do the opposite. Every single promise they make, they resile. The question must be asked: can they point to a single social intervention programme since they assumed office in January, 2025? Mr Speaker, for the avoidance of doubt, when Ghanaians mention Free SHS, they know who? Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. When the Ghanaians mention health insurance, they know former President John Kufour. We can boast of the Free Maternal Care.

Mr Speaker, if the Ghanaian people mention School Feeding Programme, they know of the New Patriotic Party (NPP). If the Ghanaian people mention Free Maternal Care, they know of NPP. If the Ghanaian people mention Health Insurance Policy, they know NPP. Investment in public transport, they even called it “Kufuor Bus,” they know NPP. *[Hear! Hear!]* Mr Speaker, when the Ghanaian people hear of the almighty Free SHS, they know of NPP. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, but when the Ghanaian people mention a government that

abandoned job creation and decided to buy an aeroplane for the President to fly in, they know of —**[Some Hon Members: NDC]**. When the Ghanaian people mention leadership of deceit, hypocrisy, propaganda, they mention — **[Some Hon Members: NDC]**. When the people of Ghana mention of deceit in the implementation of one job, three shifts, they mention—**[Some Hon Members: NDC]**. Mr Speaker, when they mention the double standard government that said it frowns against that river, yet comes into this Chamber claiming that it is rather streamlining a contract signed by the previous Government, and grants a whopping US\$10.4 million to a single entity, they mention —**[Some Hon Members: NDC]**. I want to challenge the NDC, if indeed the Tata contract was that bad, go and cancel it. Go and cancel it. We do not want you to streamline it. Do not come and protect anybody, go and cancel it. Come back to Parliament for the review of the Resolution and cancel the contract. Cancel it. About US\$10.4 million to one company.

Mr Speaker, our Friends in the NDC, it appears that they got the power, they are dazed, they have lost control in just 12 months. Today, there are Ministers who appeared in this Chamber, anytime we ask them, ‘have you received your releases?’, they are unable to answer. I want each of the Ministers to dare the Minority and be bold and state for the *Hansard* whether indeed they received their releases. They received nothing. The Government could not even prioritise its own programmes. The Government could not even implement its own programmes. Ministers were left

idle. Ministers were abandoned, and Ministers became redundant. For those who were privileged to be Members of this House, they found refuge in this House. This was their hiding place. They made themselves busy by always coming to this Chamber instead of being at their offices to execute Government business. Because *sika no wɔ hen*? It is bizarre.

Ato is indeed forcing. He is forcing. He is forcing the youth out of jobs. He is forcing to get 18 per cent electricity tariffs. He is forcing to ensure that he creates a new VAT basket, to compel many of our small scale businesses to get into this new threshold. Mr Speaker, do they know what they are going to do? Ato, is forcing many people out of jobs. If one meets a Minister and say Ato is forcing, it is not me *oo*. It is Ato. *Ei Ato!*

Mr Speaker, to conclude, even Parliament is given a paltry sum. Parliament has not been given sufficient allocation for its activities. Is it a Government that cares? Must Parliament beg the Government for its releases? Must Government be begged for money to undertake its activities? Mr Speaker, today, after succeeding in what I will call, the Minority will call, judicial capture, they are on their way to ensuring Electoral Commission capture.

3:32 p.m.

But we tell them one thing, no matter what they do, no matter the intimidation, we, the mighty Minority—*[Hear! Hear!]*—know that the better days of our country are ahead of us. We would hold their feet to the fire, expose their

incompetence, and all the promises they made that they are unable to fulfil. We will not allow them to use propaganda to distract anybody. We will stay on course and hold them accountable to the very things they promised.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance was not here, but at the risk of being repetitive, Ghana Railway Development Authority; is there any railway ministry? Is there any Ministry of Works and Housing? He should go and check page 74, 75 and 76. Perhaps, we may forgive the Minister for Finance because he has an added responsibility at the Ministry of Defence. This is because they want him to buy the aircrafts before he leaves there. Otherwise, why have they not appointed a new Minister for Defence? They want him to finish that transaction. But where were his Deputy Minister, technocrats and the various Ministers, including the Minister for Roads and Highways?

Did this Budget go to Cabinet? Did they read over this Budget? This has never happened in the history of this country. The Minister for Finance brought a Budget of mistakes. He did not read over his Budget. Mr Speaker, by extension, every figure in this Budget is compromised. We must now watch his figures again. That is how come he claims that within three months, they are going to achieve GH¢74 billion in revenue, when over nine months, they could achieve nothing much.

Mr Speaker, I shall conclude by urging the Minister for Finance to take a cue from all the submissions from this Side

of the House, having exposed all the inaccuracies in this Budget and all the propaganda in this Budget, including all the submissions I have made at this Despatch box, specifically on pages 74, 75 and 76, and without delay—let me use the legal terminology—withdraw this Budget Statement and Economic Policy forthwith and go back to do the right thing. Mr Speaker, I rest my case.
[Uproar]

[The First Deputy Speaker rises to be heard in silence pursuant to Standing Order 126 (2)]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a House guided by rules. I will therefore refer to Standing Order 63, which has the marginal note, “Language of Proceedings”. I want to read Order 63 (1):

“The proceedings of Parliament shall ordinarily be conducted in English, except that a Member may exercise the option to address the House in a local language if facilities exist in the House for the interpretation by the Member or for contemporaneous interpretation.”

Hon Members, in clear violation, Twi and Ga has been spoken by the Minority Leader, which substantially has not been translated into English. Accordingly, I will order and direct that all the Twi and Ga words spoken which have not been translated into English, be expunged from the record as if they do not exist.
[Uproar]

Hon Members, I will proceed to give the floor to the Majority Leader, Mr Mahama Ayariga. You have one hour.
[Hear! Hear!]

[The First Deputy Speaker rises to be heard in silence pursuant to Standing Order 126 (2)]

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Thank you, Mr Speaker, and thank you, Colleagues. Let me thank all Colleagues on this Side of the House and across the aisle for their very revealing and informing comments on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Once again, some of our First-Timers have risen to the occasion and made us very proud in this Chamber by making very impressive comments on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Their boldness and effective contribution have not gone unnoticed. A lot has been said in favour of the Budget, and a lot has been said against the Budget. I will reaffirm some of the good things and I will respond to some of the criticisms.

This Budget and the policies underpinning it is to reset Ghana for growth, jobs and transformation—[Hear! Hear!]
—Mr Speaker, this is a Budget that will generate growth. This is a Budget that reflects prudent management of the resources of this economy to achieve growth objectives. In one year, we have shifted gears from a criminal handling of the economy to prudence. Indeed, the President had cause to describe the situation we met in this country as a crime scene.

Let me start with the energy sector. What is the record of the New Patriotic Party (NPP) in the energy sector? They mismanaged the Millennium Challenge Account (MCA) Energy Compact II. In the process, they cost this country and we lost US\$190 million by giving the distribution sector to a certain Power Distribution Services (PDS), which went and forged records in providing a payment guarantee. This is the record of the NPP in the management of the energy sector.

Mr Speaker, do they want what is in the Budget? The situation at the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) is in the Budget.

3:42 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the recent container hold-up investigations report of the ECG reveals the mess at the ECG. Due to their negligence, demurrage of over GH¢909 million was incurred at the port—*[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, corruption was at its height. Clearing contracts to the tune of GH¢159 million was awarded. Mr Speaker, a GH¢127.6 million contract was awarded to a company which did not have customs house agent registration —*[Interruption]*—There were massive deviations in the budget for procurement *vis-a-vis* actual procurements. The 2024 planned procurement and my Friend opposite in 2024 at some point, was the chairman of ECG Board—*[Interruption]*—The 2024 planned procurement was GH¢1.3 billion but actual procurement was GH¢6.8 billion.

A deviation of negative 487 per cent. All these contracts were sole-sourced; they were single-sourced procurements.

Mr Speaker, ECG owed power producers over GH¢60 billion. As of December 2024, ECG owed power producers over GH¢60 billion. The energy sector as a whole owed over US\$1.46 billion. That is over GH¢20.8 billion. He stands here and he asked us, when is the 24-Hour Economy starting? The 24-Hour Economy will start when we have cleared the mess at ECG and we have created a 24-Hour energy sector. *[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, what is the NDC's management of the energy sector? What does the Budget say? The Budget says that the energy sector has been better managed. We suspended all power purchase agreements. We migrated all non-strategic state-owned facilities to prepaid metering systems. We are reintroducing private sector participation in power distribution without a Power Distribution Service (PDS) scandal—*[Hear! Hear!]*—A second gas processing plant is being developed to save Ghana an annual expenditure of US\$350 million on liquid fuels to power generators—*[Hear! Hear!]* We are managing the energy sector more efficiently. With this project, that is the second gas processing plant, we would save US\$481 million in forex every year. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, for those who are asking where the jobs are? When we construct the second gas processing plant, we

would create 1,500 new direct and indirect jobs for the youth—*[Hear! Hear!]*—We have renegotiated the Independent Power Producers (IPP) payments from US\$1.4 billion and we are paying US\$1.1 billion. We have saved Ghana US\$250 million in the renegotiation exercise. Even the US\$ 1.1 billion, we are spreading it over four years. As we speak, this Budget reports that we are current on our payments to the (IPPs).

Last week, when I was flying into Accra from Kumasi at night, it was a sight to behold. Everywhere was lighted—*[Hear! Hear!]*—It was not like in the NPP era. I challenge them. When they go to Kumasi, they should fly back at night and as they descend into Accra, they would see the beauty of Accra under the NDC.

Mr Speaker, we are fully current and this Budget reports that US\$300 million have been paid to IPPs and that is why energy is now reliably supplied. We programme to pay US\$345 million in 2026. This Budget reports that ECG is better managed now. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Let me at this juncture single out for mention, the excellent handling of ECG by its acting Managing Director, Ing. Julius Kpekpena—*[Hear! Hear!]*—That proud product of Keta Secondary School and St. Augustine's College has proven that Ghanaians have what it takes to turn things around and we will turn things around. *[Hear! Hear!]*

In 2025, unlike the mess he inherited, he achieved 115 per cent reduction in

administrative expenses from GH¢ 930 million in 2024, half-year to 2025, half of it which was 115 per cent, was achieved. The 115 percent reduction in administrative expenses—

The infamous Hubtel Contract was renegotiated from 3 per cent to 1.65 per cent and in the process, he saved Ghana GH¢13.2 million monthly—*[Interruption]*—The GH¢13.2 million every month can construct many schools and hospitals in their constituencies. It can add to the construction of Agenda 111 Hospitals and he has saved that.

Mr Speaker, he has terminated 202 underperforming contracts, saving US\$227 million and to cap it, he delivered a record-breaking revenue collection of GH¢1.7 billion in June 2025. It has never happened. Why am I saying so? I am saying that this Budget reflects a turnaround. Even institutions like ECG, which were totally and corruptly mismanaged and run bankrupt—even ECG has been managed so well that there is a turnaround.

Mr Speaker, all the agencies have similar impressive records. All the state-owned companies have similar impressive records. I just singled out ECG as an example. But all of them, for example the Ghana Ports and Harbours Authority and every one of the other authorities are all performing very well. If they check, they would confirm what I have said.

Mr Speaker, let us go to the mining sector. Gold exports increased by 71.4

per cent. We moved it, earnings from gold is US\$13.3 billion, when last year, NPP got only US\$7.7 billion. So, from US\$7.7 billion to US\$13.3 billion. That is because Hon Ato Forson, a very smart person— “Forson” forced and introduced the policy of GoldBod. [Hear! Hear!]

3:52 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the introduction of the GoldBod completely transformed the sector. And we are seeing the impressive results.

Mr Speaker. The debate about anti-*galamsey* fight. I have heard Members on the opposite Side indicate that because we allocated only GH¢150 million, then we are not committed to the debate against, the fight against *galamsey*. I am surprised. Who are we using to fight *galamsey*? We are using soldiers, the police and security agencies. Is their budget part of this GH¢ 150 million?

Some Hon Members: No!

Mr Ayariga: They have their separate budgetary allocation.

Some Hon Members: Yes!

Mr Ayariga: That budgetary allocation will go to fight *galamsey* and if they need additional resources, then we will add the GH¢ 150 million to them.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Speaker, let me add that if we want to be very successful in fighting

galamsey, we must support the retooling of our security agencies. [Hear! Hear!] So, the budget to buy new helicopters, military equipment for the Armed Forces, will all go towards making Ghana capable of fighting *galamsey* successfully.

Mr Speaker. I have heard Colleagues question the amount allocated for retooling the security agencies. If you see the number of young people who thronged the various stadia, looking to have an opportunity to serve in those agencies and the services, you will see the need for us to invest in those services. This is because our youth want to join the Army, the Air Force and the Navy and if we do not retool and invest in them, when they join, what will they be doing there?

This Budget Statement and Economic Policy has a provision for the cancellation of the tax on prospecting. If we cancel the tax on prospecting, do you know what will happen? Many of the areas that are plagued with illegal mining activities tend to be people's concessions and because they have difficulty in prospecting, they are not developing them. When we cancel the tax on prospecting, all these companies will move in and prospect. When they prospect, they will relinquish some areas and we can convert those areas into community mining sites.

Mr Speaker, we can also establish medium and small-scale mining licences there and those people who are engaged in *galamsey*— When we go to all the places where we have serious problems,

we will find out that the *galamsey* activities are happening in people's concessions and we need to encourage them to relinquish them. They will only do so after they have prospected and established that they do not need those sites. But small-scale miners can do well at those sites.

Mr Speaker, what is the track record of the NPP when it comes to the management of our gold? We have not forgotten about the royalties' deal; Agyapa royalties. When they attempted to sell all the future gold of this country, they tried to sell all the gold that would be mined in this country, the royalties.

They wanted to collect the money ahead and spend it. It was when Ghanaians resisted that they stopped. That is why my uncle, Martin Amidu, in his corruption risk analysis, described someone as the mother serpent of corruption. It was as a result of what happened in the attempt to force Agyapa royalties on the people of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, let me go to the health sector. What is the track record of the NPP? I remember during the period of COVID-19, there were times when we would be locked up in our rooms and then a certain man would come and say "fellow Ghanaians". Update number eight of fellow Ghanaians was when he promised 88 regional and district hospitals. It later increased to 111 —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Emmanuel Tobbin, MP for Anyaa-Sowutuom, why are you in the habit of shouting from the back? Please, I did not

give you the floor to be on your feet. Please. Why? [*Uproar*] We are all Hon Members and we need to behave as such.

Majority leader, you may continue.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, he, during the eighth update on Sunday 26th April, 2020, promised to construct 88 regional and district hospitals within one year and later increased it to 111 hospitals. Each district hospital was to cost US\$17 million. How many beds? 120 beds. Regional hospitals, each to cost US\$87 million. How many beds? 160 beds. The NPP spent US\$400 million dollars without finishing one single hospital—[*Uproar*]
US\$400 million dollars and they did not finish one.

Mr Speaker, let us talk about corruption. Let me recall my Ffulso primary school mathematics. Let me recall the assistance of my Ffulso primary school mathematics. An of US\$85 million dollars for a 160-bed hospital comes to US\$531,000.00 per bed—[*Uproar*]. The NPP wanted to construct hospitals and per bed, it will cost the country US\$531,000.00—Ffulso mathematics.

Mr Speaker, for the district hospitals, US\$17 million dollars per 120-bed hospital. By the same Ffulso mathematics standards, each bed is going to cost the Ghanaian US\$141,000.00. [*Uproar*] My Hon Brother, the Minority Leader, has constructed a big hospital in his constituency. I am aware. He said it in this Parliament, in Winneba. Is that how much he constructed the hospital for, per bed?

Mr Speaker, this is a scandal of monumental proportions and like I said, US\$400 million spent, and not one single hospital completed. When even one district hospital is just US\$17 million, by your standard. If they divide US\$400 million by US\$17 million, how many would they have completed by now? And they stood in this Chamber for the past one week, without any debating point, except to say that we have not made provision for the completion of Agenda 111 hospitals. If they wanted to finish Agenda 111 hospitals, they would have done so and I would show them how.

4:02 p.m.

Mr Speaker, as elections approached, they pretended that three of the hospitals had been completed. One at Trede, one at Kokoben, the other at Bokoro. What did they do? They hired generators, put lights on, got the old man, His Excellency the former President, to inaugurate it, put up a plaque, and when he left, they took the generators away and locked up the place. So, not even one hospital is functioning. They promised 111 hospitals as far back as 2021, and they delivered zero. The NDC has been in office for only nine months, and they expect all the hospitals to be finished. Can you imagine that? What level of expectation is this?

Mr Speaker, the health sector is doing well now. The National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA) had its fund uncapped, and since then, an additional GH¢3.4 billion has flown into the National Health Insurance Scheme

(NHIS); the highest in the history of the scheme.

Mr Speaker, health care providers are now more confident. They know that when they treat patients and they make a claim under the (NHIS), they will be reimbursed. There is greater confidence in NHIA. It has become financially reliable, stable and is trusted by providers. Under the NPP, it was collapsing.

Mr Speaker, I have heard from this Side that adding the expenditure on the Ghana Medical Trust Fund, MahamaCares, amounts to capping NHIA funds. This kind of argument can only be coming from people who are groping in the dark for an argument because they do not have one.

If we had not awarded a US\$100 million contract to Lightwave Solutions Limited for simply maintaining the records of hospitals, they would have had more money to finish the Agenda 111 hospitals.

Mr Speaker, on the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund), they borrowed under the Daakye Bond and spent all the money ahead of its collection. They have forgotten; that is how they managed GETFund. We came, and we have uncapped GETFund. Because we have uncapped GETFund, so much money is going there.

Mr Speaker, they are claiming that they introduced the Free SHS programme, but we can say we are better

implementers of the Free SHS Programme. They are claiming that they introduced the NHIA. I can say here that we are better implementers of NHIA, because when one introduces and does not finance it well, the system will collapse.

Mr Speaker, the Common Fund has now become common. Under the NPP, the Common Fund was uncommon because they never released the money. We have uncapped, and we are making sure that 80 per cent of the Common Fund money is going to the Assemblies directly. It is enriching, creating jobs in the districts, and boosting the local economy. I can see that inflation has reduced. When we look at the indicators, they are performing well. All because there is vibrant economic activity taking place at the local level.

Mr Speaker, on the issue of taxes, this economy was burdened with the Electronic Transfer Levy (e-Levy), and we have moved to an economy that is free from the e-Levy. They stood in this Chamber and said that this economy will collapse if the e-Levy was not imposed; we have removed the e-Levy, and the economy is doing better. When we needed roads or hospitals, they would say we should allow them to pass the e-Levy. When we say they should employ teachers, they will say we should allow them to pass the e-Levy. They forced us to pass the e-Levy. We have removed the e-Levy, and the economy is doing better.

Mr Speaker, this Budget marks a shift from an economy burdened by the COVID-19 levy to an economy that is

free from the COVID-19 levy; the COVID-19 levy has been taken away.

Mr Speaker, this Budget has also confirmed that our decision earlier in the year to remove the withholding tax on gold sales is indeed revolutionising the gold subsector. An argument has been made in this House by Friends opposite that we inherited a good economy. I have heard the Minority Leader repeat that argument here, and that it is because we inherited a good economy that we are able to promptly pay our debts; I heard that.

Mr Speaker, the reason we are able to pay our debts is because we replaced fiscal recklessness and criminal management of the economy with honest, responsible fiscal management of the economy. We replaced recklessness with prudence. The era of bloated, opaque, and corrupt expenditures is no longer the order of the day, because Dr Ato Forson will not allow bloated, opaque, and corrupt expenditures. If that is what people are complaining about, this Side of the House supports him. We will spend, but we will spend on the right matters; we will spend, but we will send the money to the Common Fund; we will spend, but we will send the money to GETfund; we will spend, but we will send the money to NHIA; we will spend, but we will retool our Armed Forces. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, if this Government were dumping US\$97 million in massive holes in the name of building a cathedral, we would not have been able to honour our debt obligations. If we are looting

and plundering the resources of ECG the way it was done in the past, we will not be able to honour our debts. If we are giving Hubtel, three percent of ECG revenues, we will not be able to pay our debts. The ECG developed its own mobile app, and Hubtel came and collected US\$12 from them just to enhance the app, and after that, they were taking 3 per cent of the revenues that had been generated by the same app that ECG used their money to develop. If we are managing the economy that way, we will not be able to honour our debt obligations.

If we are wasting money on fraudulent schemes like Zipline, which was given US\$15 million to deliver blood in rural areas—Those monies could have fixed the roads in those rural areas. If Dr Ato Forson was approving moneys so that we can give US\$108 million contract for servicing and maintaining our ambulances, we would not have been able to honour our debt obligations.

One hundred and eight million dollars to service ambulances, not to buy new ambulances, but to buy spare parts and service ambulances; this is how they managed the economy. That is how they could not pay the debts; that is how they put us in the kind of debt that they put us in, and that was why they had to do the Debt Exchange programme.

Mr Speaker, if we were stealing Ghana Revenue Authority's (GRA) money under contracts similar to the Strategic Mobilisation Limited (SML), where GH¢1.5 billion was paid to SML without proper evaluation, we would not

have been able to honour our debt obligations.

Mr Speaker, on the SML, it was reported that when they added upstream oil contracts to them, the contract value ballooned to close to US\$500 million. Indeed, I have come to accept their name, Strategic Mobilisation Limited, to strategically mobilise and loot the monies of Ghanaians. If they were not strategically mobilising and looting Ghanaians' money, they would have been able to construct 111 hospitals in four years.

4:12 p.m.

Mr Speaker, now the former Minister for Finance, Mr Ken Ofori-Atta, wants us to sympathise with him that he is sick. Even when he was sick, and his own MPs wanted him to resign, he refused and said he could manage the economy despite his obvious ill health. We were all here in this Chamber. It was obvious that he was not well, but he insisted on managing the economy.

Today, he is being called to come and give account, and we are being told that we should sympathise with him because he is sick. Mr Speaker, for four good years, he turned this Chamber into a Bible school. I remember his famous Bible quotations, Matthew 14:13 to 21. He referred us to the loaves and fish parable. I remember Deuteronomy 8:18. Mr Speaker, after many years of tutelage by Mr Ken Ofori-Atta, we have also learnt the Bible. So, today, I refer him to Luke 19:1-10, and since my Brother started with a lengthy Bible quotation, let

me also go through a lengthy Bible quotation. Luke 19:1-10 says:

“Jesus entered Jericho and was passing through. A man was there by the name Zacchaeus. He was a chief tax collector”.

What was Ken Ofori-Atta? A chief tax collector. He was in charge of the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA), and what does GRA do? They collect tax. So, clearly Zacchaeus in the Bible resembles Ken Ofori-Atta.

“A man was there by the name Zacchaeus. He was a chief tax collector, and he was wealthy”.

A man who owns a bank; Databank Financial Services, and Enterprise Insurance Company. Is he not a wealthy man? Is there no resemblance between Zacchaeus and Ken Ofori-Atta?

“He wanted to see Jesus but because he was short, he could not see over the crowd. So, he ran ahead and climbed a sycamore-fig tree to see him, since Jesus was coming that way. When Jesus reached the spot, he looked up and said to him, Zacchaeus come down immediately.”

I say to Ken Ofori-Atta, come back to Ghana immediately. Zacchaeus! Zacchaeus! **[Some Hon Members: Come down immediately.]** Ofori-Atta! Ofori-Atta! **[Some Hon Members: Come down immediately.]** And Jesus said to Zacchaeus, “I must stay at your house today”. Mr Speaker, if you recall,

we tried to go and stay in his house recently.

“So he came down at once, and Jesus welcomed him gladly. All the people saw this and began to mutter, he has gone to be the guest of a sinner.”

Mr Speaker, I did not start with the Bible today. My Brother started with the Bible today, and I am just following in his footsteps, so that he knows I have not forgotten my Bible lessons. Mr Speaker, the people said,

“He has gone to be the guest of a sinner. But Zacchaeus stood up and said to the Lord, Look, Lord, here and now, I give half of my possessions to the poor, and if I have cheated anybody out of anything, I will pay back four times the amount.”

Ken Ofori-Atta, come back. If you have not cheated anybody, come back, and when you come, and we determine that you have cheated, you have to pay four times. And Jesus said to him, “Today salvation has come to this house...” —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Samuel Abu Jinapor, it appears the Members do not want you to leave. It appears they are happy about your presence. That is just by the way.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader, you have the floor.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, and Jesus said to him, "Today salvation has come to this house, because this man too is a son of Abraham." Ken Ofori-Atta too is a son of Ghana, so he should come home. "The son of man came to seek and to save the lost."

Mr Speaker, I would end my Bible lessons here. And to show to my Colleague, the Minority Leader, that he does not know the Bible better than me. *[Hear! Hear!]* If he does not know, my mother used to own a church.

Let us continue: Financial sector mismanagement of the New Patriotic Party (NPP). Paragraphs 258 to 268 speak to the good health of our financial sector. The sector is rebounding, and confidence is being restored after the NPP collapsed the sector.

The NPP destroyed the financial sector at great cost to the taxpayer, and I would demonstrate it. At the end of 2024, the government had spent GH¢29.8 billion to support the financial sector cleanup exercise; GH¢23 billion for banking and GH¢5.16 billion for the non-banking institutions.

Mr Speaker, for the damage caused, nine commercial banks were collapsed by the NPP: Unibank, Royal Bank, Beige Bank, Sovereign Bank, Construction Bank, UT Bank, Capital Bank, Premium Bank, and Heritage Bank. All these nine banks collapsed under NPP. Also, 347 microfinance institutions were collapsed by the NPP; 39 microcredit companies were collapsed, and 29 finance houses

and savings and loans companies were collapsed.

Mr Speaker, in the end, they deprived 10,000 workers of their jobs. Today, they stand here and ask us where the jobs are. When they collapsed all the banks and rendered the people jobless. Mr Speaker, let me get back to Ffulso Primary School Mathematics. They collapsed the banks and spent money, a fraction of which could have saved the banks.

4:22 p.m.

That was their style of economic management. Let me apply my Ffulso mathematics. They increased the capital adequacy ratio to GH¢400 million, then collapsed nine banks and spend GH¢11.7 billion in 2018 to clean the resultant mess of the collapse of nine banks. If we divide GH¢11.7 billion by GH¢400 million, we will get 29 banks. So, nine banks are sick.

They did not cure them. They collapse them and then spend money that could have been used to create 29 banks to deal with the mess. That was their record when it came to managing the finances of this country. This is Ffulso mathematics. Most of the banks that were collapsed were our local banks.

He talked about job creation. Let us look at the social and also the capital expenditure outlay in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. We will see clearly that those expenditures, when implemented, will definitely create jobs. Over GH¢60 billion worth of road contracts have been awarded under the

Big Push. *[Hear! Hear!]* When we hear Big Push, we should hear big jobs; Big Push, big jobs, GH¢60 billion worth of road contracts.

Can you imagine how many carpenters will be used? Can you imagine how many masons will be used? Can you imagine how many engineers will be used? Can you imagine how many truck operators will be used; how many bulldozer operators will be used; how many cement sellers will sell? Do you know how many jobs will be created by the Big Push of over US\$60 billion contracts? I am surprised that they do not understand where to spend. Why? When Donald Trump was talking about creating jobs, he talked about big expenditure. Big ticket expenditure creates big jobs. I am very confident that by the end we finish with the over GH¢60 billion Big Push projects, not less than 400,000 direct and indirect jobs will be created, and we will be halfway through our target.

Mr Speaker, we have allocated GH¢100 million for the completion of the 10 Agenda 111 hospitals. *[Uproar]*

[Mr First Deputy Speaker rises to be heard in silence]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, you may proceed.

Mr Ayariga: The kitchen is getting too hot. We have allocated GH¢100 million for the completion of the 10 Agenda 111 hospitals; many jobs. We have GH¢200 million for the construction of mini stadia; many jobs;

200 new junior high schools, many jobs. **[Some Hon Members:** Many jobs]. 200 new primary schools, many jobs; 200 kindergartens, many jobs; 400 four-unit teacher bungalows, many jobs; 400 places of convenience, many jobs. All these will create jobs.

So, I am wondering where in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy those who are saying that this Budget Statement and Economic Policy does not say anything about creating jobs were reading. Because it is littered everywhere that these measures when undertaken will definitely create jobs.

Mr Speaker, let me go to social expenditure. We have allocated GH¢1.1 billion to the Livelihood Empowerment Acceleration Programme (LEAP). It is never happened before; this is the biggest jump. We have programmed GH¢9 billion in 2026 for NHIS claims. It has never happened before. We are establishing the Women's Development Bank. They say GH¢401 million cannot establish a bank? You do not establish a bank one day. The team needs the GH¢401 million first to go through the process of acquiring the licence from the Central Bank. That is what they need first. If they have not acquired their licence, on what basis would they now be taking money to build banking halls? So, you need the money for the banking licence first, and that is why we have GH¢401 million to meet the capital adequacy requirement.

Mr Speaker, GH¢170 million for the National Apprenticeship Programme, social expenditure, skills building, jobs;

GH¢169 million for BECE registration; GH¢474 million for nursing training allowances; GH¢2.3 billion for MahamaCares; GH¢292 million for free sanitary pads. They spoke about sanitary pads. I am sure at the right time the Minister for Education will give us the actual prices and the quantity of the sanitary pads that have been procured. And GH¢50 million has also been allocated for the procurement of fishing nets; GH¢20 million for the creative arts. All these allocations and the expenditure will create jobs.

Now they talk about the 24-Hour Economy. The 24-Hour Economy is not an event so that he can say it has not happened. The 24-Hour Economy is a process; it is a process of enabling a quantum leap in our national productive capacity so that we will produce 24 hours. [*Hear! Hear!*]

One fundamental component of being able to produce 24 hours is to enhance the security. If we cannot secure banks to open beyond a certain point, they cannot work 24 hours. If we cannot secure filling stations to open 24 hours, can they open 24 hours? They cannot because of security. If there is no adequate energy supply, there will be no 24-hour economy. So, we are dealing with a fundamental issue that will enable a 24-Hour Economy.

Mr Speaker, and it is a lie that we have overcapacity when it comes to energy generation. I can assure the House that as we speak, we are consuming all our installed capacity. Check from the Minister for Energy and Green

Transition, he will tell you, it is not because of 1D1F, but because the private sector has suddenly become confident in our economy and they are investing and they are producing and they are using energy.

That is what is generating the surge in the utilisation of our energy. So, we are almost at that point where we are going to get overstretched in terms of the supply of energy. That is why we are introducing structural reforms. We are building a second gas processing plant so that we can bring in more independent power producers. And that is why we are thinking smart. And instead of keeping our billions of dollars in accounts in the US, which is generating only 1 per cent for us, we will rather bring it back here and then we will use it to establish our own power generation plants and we will produce power at a much cheaper cost. So, we are thinking smart. This Budget is thinking smart.

Mr Speaker, finally, let me announce that the Bill to establish the 24-Hour Economy Authority is in this House. It has arrived. What they have been asking about, the Bill to establish the 24-Hour Economy Authority has landed. *Aclicki*; it has clicked. *Apicki*; it has picked.

4:32 p.m.

And my Brother stood here and said that John Mahama had increased electricity tariffs by over 18 per cent in 2025. We all listen to the radio, and I have not heard the announcement of a tariff increment of 18 per cent in this country.

We were invited to a session organised by the Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC). They established that in 2024, when the NPP government was supposed to allow them to increase electricity tariffs, they prevented them from doing so. And that is how the debts accumulated, because the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) was not making enough money to pay those debts. So, they were pleading with us to allow them to increase the tariffs. But no increment has been made yet. That is the job of PURC. So, Mr Speaker, that statement that he made here, that tariffs have been increased by 18 per cent, is totally untrue. It is false.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by thanking the Minister for Finance for bringing such an excellent Budget to this House. For such excellent, smart, forward-looking plans and strategies to transform our economy. Mr Speaker, major initiatives have been planned; there is a plan to construct a sewage treatment plant to replace the existing one here.

There is a plan to construct an interconnecting concourse between Terminal 2 and Terminal 3. All those are jobs. There is a plan to construct a multi-purpose, multi-storey car park at Terminal 3. Jobs will be created. Sunyani Airport runway and terminal renovation and extension will happen. Bolgatanga Airport will be developed. *[Hear! Hear!]* The Wa Airport will be renovated. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, as for social interventions, I am surprised that he does

not know that No Fee Stress is a social intervention. I am surprised that he does not know that MahamaCares is a social intervention. I am surprised that he does not know that all the money that we are spending on education through GETFund, which was established under the NDC, is a social intervention. And I am surprised that he does not know that the Common Fund, which was established in the Constitution, passed by the NDC, at the time that the PNDC was in office, is a major social intervention. *[Hear! Hear!]* So, we have a longer history of social intervention than they can recount. So, I do not want them to ever say that the NDC has never introduced a social intervention.

Mr Speaker, on that note, let me thank honourable Colleagues and the Minister and say that this year's commentary on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy has been very impressive; I am impressed with the contributions. And from this stage, I believe we will go and consider the sector budgets. I urge Chairpersons and Ranking Members to use the facilities that we have created, which is a live telecast of Committee Budget Hearings, so that the public can see the work that we do at the Committee in the consideration of the Budget.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much.

[Members of the Majority Caucus chanted "Leader o Leader!"]

[The First Deputy Speaker rises to be heard in silence pursuant to Standing Order 126(2).]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me use the opportunity to thank the two Leaders for their concluding remarks. I will, therefore, give the floor to the Minister who presented the Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Minister for Finance (Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson) (MP): Mr Speaker, thanks for the opportunity to make a concluding statement to bring the debate on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy to a close.

Mr Speaker, two weeks ago, acting under the authority of His Excellency the President, I presented the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government to this House. Since then, Mr Speaker, Hon Members have taken their turns to interrogate policies and proposals. Many contributions have been constructive. Others, regrettably, were built on deliberate mischiefs, misunderstanding, selective reading of data or arguments that collapse the moment we placed them beside the facts.

Mr Speaker, this is a House of records. So, in conclusion, I will take my time to correct some misimpressions and information that has been placed in the *Hansard*.

Mr Speaker, first let me start with a statement made by Hon Abena Osei-Asare on industry growth and the One District One Factory (1D1F) argument. My Colleague, Hon Abena Osei-Asare, claimed that industry slowed because of 1D1F and that 1D1F has been cancelled, and as a result, the industry growth has

slowed. According to the Ghana Statistical Service, the oil and gas subsector contracted by 18.1 per cent in the first quarter of 2025 and 22.5 per cent in the second quarter, averaging about 20.1 per cent in the first half of 2025. That single structural shock pulled overall industry growth down to 3.4 per cent in the first half of 2025.

The cause was clear, Mr Speaker, and this is because of three things: one, corruption in the sector; two, underinvestment; and most importantly, operational decline in the petroleum volumes, as we have seen.

Mr Speaker, it had nothing to do with the cancellation or realignment of the 1D1F. Even more interestingly, the subsector in which 1D1F beneficiaries actually sat grew by 6.3 per cent in the first half of 2025. So, I am surprised to hear a former Minister of State at the Ministry of Finance make an argument that is not founded on data.

Mr Speaker, clearly, this has been misinterpreted, and the actual details are not coming out. This Budget Statement and Economic Policy expands; it does not constrain.

Mr Speaker, let me take my time to point to certain key factors, expenditure lines in the Budget that will expand industry. We are rolling out US\$500 million oil palm development financing window. We are also acquiring 4,000 agricultural machineries to boost the industry. We have created new incentives for textiles, agro-processing and the pharmaceutical industry that are

export-orientated. Mr Speaker, these are all in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Speaker, in addition, the Value Added Tax (VAT) reforms are designed to foster business expansions and create new job opportunities. Mr Speaker, I had my good Friend and Brother, Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin, also known as Chairman One *[Laughter]*, making a statement that we have rather added small businesses into the VAT net. Mr Speaker, I have always cautioned him that I know him to be a lawyer; I know him to be a litigant, but I do not know him to be a tax expert. So, when it comes to areas of taxes, he should defer that to me, and I will help him accordingly. *[Hear! Hear!]*

4:42 p.m.

Mr Speaker, rather what this Government has done is that we have exempted businesses turning over up to GH¢750,000 from charging and collecting of VAT. This is a Government that cares. The evidence before us does not support the conclusion that cancelling One District One Factory (1D1F) has caused the industry sector to rather decline. In fact, it is contrary to the statement that was made by Ms Abena Osei-Asare.

On the fiscal side, Dr Gideon Boako made some statement that it is important that I clarify. He argued that we missed at least 50 per cent of our Budget target. It is a curious and an inaccurate claim because none of our macro data supports these assertions from him. On the

contrary, we have met every single macro indicator that we announced in 2025. In fact, we have overperformed.

Mr Speaker, let me take my time to take Hon Members through it. Growth for the first half of the year stood at 6.3 per cent, comfortably above the revised target of 4 per cent. This simple means we actually programmed for 4 per cent and we are doing 6.3 per cent. We have overperformed.

Mr Speaker, in the second quarter inflation fell from 23.8 per cent in 2024 to 8 per cent by October 2025. Mr Speaker, our target was actually 11 per cent. We have overperformed. We have not missed the target. Let me say it again, Mr Speaker, we programmed to grow by 4 per cent. As at first half of the year, second quarter, we have grown 6.3 per cent. Mr Speaker, I urge my Colleagues to listen to the Government Statistician when he is speaking. The primary balance swung from a deficit of 3 per cent of GDP in 2024 to a surplus of 1.6 per cent in September, 2025.

Mr Speaker, that is not underperformance, it is indeed overperformance. In fact, we programmed to do 1.5 per cent of GDP. We have actually exceeded that. The public debt as of October 2025, decreased from 61.8 per cent of GDP to 45 per cent of GDP. Mr Speaker, 45 per cent of GDP. Gross reserves strengthened from four months of import cover to 4.8 months of import cover. We have not only achieved every single indicator, but we have actually outperformed the target. These are facts.

They are recognised by the markets, the investor community, rating agencies and international communities, including the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and the World Bank. These are facts. This is not a profile of a government that misses targets. In fact, this is a profile of a government that is regaining credibility through discipline, and that is the record of President Mahama's Administration.

I now take Hon Members to growth, jobs and the logic that our Colleague from the NPP raised. The Minority, through Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, Mrs Abena Osei-Asare, and Dr Amin Adam said projecting 4.8 projecting growth in 2026 after a strong first half growth in 2025 is illogical. In truth, it is responsible rather. It is not illogical, but rather it shows how a responsible government should act. We prefer realism to wishful forecasting. That is why our growth assumptions are anchored in evidence, not political bravado. This is critical for economic management.

Mr Speaker, because they are anchored in evidence, they are also very credible, and we will ensure that these credible projections are achieved by the end of the year. Dr Amin Adam further cast doubt on inflation outturns and suggested that the 2026 Budget is growthless and jobless. This assertion is also far from accurate. Indeed, it cannot be the case. Ghana's disinflation is not a coincidence, but as a result of deliberate policy interventions. We did not just achieve the numbers that we are seeing. It is as a result of deliberate policy interventions implemented by the Mahama administration. Data from the

Ghana Statistical Service showed that food inflation was the main driver of price volatilities that we saw. So, we responded with targeted, large-scale supply-side actions.

Mr Speaker, we took those data very seriously, and we responded appropriately. Let me tell Hon Members what we did. The Feed Ghana Input Expansion and Vegetable Value Chain, as we can find in the Budget in paragraph 430 to 433, tells Members exactly what we have done. Irrigation covering more than 10,000 hectares also tells us exactly what we have done. Mechanisation through the Farmer's Service Centre will tell Members exactly what we are doing to tackle food inflation. No wonder inflation is declining from 23 per cent to 8 per cent, and projected to go down more.

We are backing this with a construction of a 1,000-kilometre agriculture enclave route to cut transport costs and ease market access. Aside that, we are investing GH¢200 million through the National Buffer Stock Company to be able to buy excess and glut food in the market. This is what it means for us to use data to shape Government policy.

Mr Speaker, I take Members now to what we call the credit rating agency and the stability story, as was criticised by the Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo. The Hon Colleague, Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo, argued that Ghana's credit rating upgrade was as a result of high commodity prices. Let me put on record that cocoa and gold prices did not

suddenly jump in 2025. They were high in the year 2023 as well, yet in 2023, under the previous administration, the cedi collapsed when commodity prices were high. Reserves declined when commodity prices were high. That actually save—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, you can pause for now. The Speaker will take the Chair.

Please, Hon Minister, you may continue.

4:50 p.m. —

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN, IN THE CHAIR]

Dr C. A. B. Forson: Mr Speaker, in 2023, under the previous administration, the cedi collapsed when, in fact, commodity prices had recorded an all-time high. International Reserves declined when cocoa prices surged and gold prices went up. That actually surged. Inflation actually worsened. At the time, the Ukraine-Russia war had not intensified, yet the cedi fell. Today, there is Ukraine and there is Russia conflict ongoing. In fact, it has intensified, yet the currency has stabilised. The difference is not commodity price. The difference can certainly not be commodity price, but rather competent management and quality management.

That is what we see. In the words of Standards and Poor (S&P), and I quote, “Standards and Poor statement credited Ghana’s upgrade to improve fiscal

discipline, stronger buffers, and credible consolidation path.” That is the words of S&P. They did not just attribute it to commodity price, and so the Hon Member cannot be right. These are policy outcomes. They are as a result of choices made by H. E. President Mahama, deliberate choices made by President Mahama.

Mr Speaker, on our fiscal path and homegrown policy. It is important for me to make this point. Mr Speaker, let me be blunt. Stability did not return because of the IMF programme alone, as the core Members of the Minority claimed, stability returned because this Government chose a fundamentally different path, an expenditure led consolidation instead of revenue led consolidation that protected citizens from further tax fatigue.

That is exactly what President Mahama decided to do. We cut waste, we reset expenditure to 2023 levels, we enforced commitment control, we audited arrears, we aligned cash to priorities, we restored discipline across MDAs and coordinated monetary policy with a clear anchor.

Mr Speaker, we did not leave the Central Bank alone to anchor the national currency. The Ministry of Finance and the Government got involved to anchor the national currency. That is the difference that we see. That is how one restores confidence. That is how one stabilises a currency, and that is how one rebuilds credibility across an economy. Mr Speaker, that is important to know.

4:52 p.m.

Mr Speaker, on the security sector, our Colleague, the Hon John Ntim Fordjour made some wild claims that our security investment amounts to luxury spending. This cannot be accurate. There is a need for us to retool the security sector and it is important that as a country we come together and do that. This Administration inherited a security sector that has been starved of modern equipment. We are correcting it. The aircrafts referenced in the Budget are not luxury aircrafts. I want to use this opportunity to assure this House that the aircraft and the helicopters that will be purchased by the Ghana Armed Forces will certainly not have a bathroom and it is important I make that point.

They are strategic mobility assets for troop deployment, emergency response, border security and peacekeeping. It will be for the use of the Ghana Armed Forces. No serious country leaves its soldiers under-resourced and no responsible government makes an ad-hoc purchase without an integrated capacity plan.

Our approach is strategic, sequenced and fiscally responsible. In fact, the US\$96 million that has been spent on the national cathedral of which we see only a borehole can actually buy more than the four helicopters that we are buying for the Ghana Armed Forces. Let me put on record that the Ghana Armed Forces is not engaging any middleman. They are working directly, country to country, to acquire this aircraft for the people of Ghana and for the Ghana Armed Forces.

On the issue of the Accra-Kumasi expressway, let me take my time to correct some impressions. Hon Asenso-Boakye suggested that the proposed Accra-Kumasi expressway is wasteful and that they in the opposition oppose the dualisation. That cannot be the case. I was surprised and amazed to see a colleague Member of Parliament (MP), particularly an MP from Kumasi, describe the project as wasteful. Mr Speaker, an MP whose constituency the road leads to is saying that the road is wasteful. To the extent that the said MP wrote to the President to say to the President that he should not do that project. Mr Speaker, I was surprised to hear that.

Mr Speaker, let me say that this road from Accra to Kumasi is more than a road. It is opening up a country. So, for an MP from that area to write to the President to say that the road is wasteful and we should not do it, is untenable.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh — *rose* —

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am grateful for your indulgence. When we met at Conclave, the prior agreement was that the Leaders would conclude, then the Minister, our Colleague, walked in and then prayed you that he has some 15 minutes. We do not have a problem, and that has been a practice. Ministers of Finance, when they present their Budget Statements and Economic Policies, get the opportunity to give closing remarks.

Mr Speaker, our Colleague is mentioning specific names and then—*[Interruption]*—Would they listen? Mr Speaker, if anybody on the Majority Side wishes to speak, they should get up and catch the eye of the Speaker. It cannot be. We do not have a problem if the Minister is giving closing remarks. He begged for 15 minutes, but now he is mentioning specific Members and attacking them. In this case, these Colleagues are not in the Chamber. *[Uproar]* Mr Speaker, I think it is important our Colleagues come to terms with the fact that this House is a two-Sided House. They have their Side and we have our Side. I am speaking and they are interrupting me. Why? They should get up and catch the eye of the Speaker. They cannot interrupt me. That is how decent discussions are had.

The Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, please, I allowed you because I thought you were going to raise a point of order. So far, you have not done that.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I with respect, if I may. Mr Speaker, I did not want to come under Order 122.

The Speaker: Hon Member, you may not. Please, let the Minister conclude.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: He should be concluding, but he is attacking us. We will not get the opportunity to rebut.

Dr C. A. B. Forson: Mr Speaker, I began my submission by saying that this is a House of records and that it is important for me to correct some misimpressions created during the debate. Mr Speaker, throughout the

debate, I made sure my Deputy Minister sat to listen and staff from the Ministry of Finance also sat at the Public Gallery to take notes. This was so that I would be able to respond during the conclusion. What I am doing here is to correct the misimpressions and to put on record that these data, as being provided by my Colleagues on the opposite Side cannot be accurate.

Mr Speaker, on the issue relating to the Accra-Kumasi Expressway, I wish the Hon Colleague Member of Parliament who made that statement were here in this House, so that I can challenge him that if he has not written to the President saying—Mr Speaker, I am not alleging, I want him to prove it. I want him to first deny here so that I can provide you with evidence.

He did not only stop there. He went on to describe the road from Accra to Kumasi, the first expressway of its kind, as wasteful. It cannot be wasteful; it is actually transformational. It is what will open this country up. The Chinese say that if you want to get rich, build roads first. We will get rich and we will build the roads that will connect this country properly.

Mr Speaker, let me use this opportunity to also correct some misimpressions around the Value for Money office. Mr Speaker, the Hon Lawrence Agyinsam misunderstands the purpose of the Value for Money office and he made assertions of that during his presentation. He is of the view that Public Procurement Authority (PPA) can

perform that function. Let me take my time to explain what this Value for Money office seeks to do.

The PPA actually ensures compliance with procurement processes. It was never designed to undertake rigorous technical engineering and financial audits of billions of Ghana cedis of infrastructure projects. That is not a mandate of PPA. Mr Speaker, Ghana needs both compliance and value for money. That is why the Value for Money Office is not a duplication. It is rather a protection. It is a firewall between taxpayers and inflated contracts.

Mr Speaker, it is important for us to understand that PPA cannot be the same as Value for Money office. I can simplify why Ghana needs a Value for Money Office in six bullet points only.

Mr Speaker, firstly, procurement compliance is not value for money. The PPA focuses on procurement procedures, not cost efficiency, life cycle costing, technical soundness or post contract verification. Again, this closes legal and institutional gaps in the Public Financial Management Act, 2016.

5:02 p.m.

The current PFM regulation requires PFM assessment only for single-source procurement. A dedicated PFM office extends this assurance to all public projects, procurement methods, and funding sources, including Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs), State-Owned Enterprises (SOEs), Internally Generated Funds (IGF) projects, and

donor funded projects. This has never been the case under the old architecture, and so it is important for us to correct that. This will also prevent inflated prices and cost overruns. Ghana lacks a central mechanism, particularly to benchmark prices, and it is important for us to create that.

Mr Speaker, again, it provides technical assurance across the entire project life cycle. That is also very important for us to actually explain. The PPA office will create an independent oversight mechanism. Up until today, that is missing, and it also aligns with Ghana and global best practices. It is also important for me to stress that today, as we speak, we have value-for-money office structures in the United States, Canada, the United Kingdom (UK), and in Singapore. All these countries today have a value-for-money office different from their procurement architecture. So, getting a PFM architecture that will ensure value-for-money by creating a value-for-money office that will be equipped with the right people will be important for our country going forward.

Mr Speaker, the PPA regulates procurement procedures and does not provide project delivery as far as fair pricing is concerned. Its mandate is limited to checking it against certain flaws that we have seen. The PFM office is adding an additional layer to ensure that our contract gets the needed pricing that is missing in this country. Unfortunately, overpricing of contracts has become a big issue in this country; it has become endemic in our country. So, it is important for us to deal with it.

Mr Speaker, I will end by making this statement. This Budget delivers the following for the ordinary Ghanaian: Mr Speaker, we allocated GH¢1.1 billion to Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) to protect the vulnerable. Aside from that, we allocated GH¢401 million for the Women's Development Bank; we allocated GH¢8.9 million for District Assemblies Common Fund. Of which, GH¢7.2 billion will go to the assemblies directly; we also allocated GH¢500 million to the District Housing Scheme; GH¢20 million was allocated to support Kumawood so that we can grow the film industry.

Mr Speaker, GH¢2.3 million was allocated to MahamaCares; GH¢3 billion was allocated for textbooks, and GH¢30 billion was allocated for the Big-Push Agenda.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by saying this: my Colleague, Osahen Afenyo-Markin, made this statement. He said that we should name a single social intervention that we have introduced since we came to office. I do not know if he has heard of the almighty "No Fees Stress"; that is a social intervention policy.

Mr Speaker, if they introduced Free SHS and failed to find sustainable sources of funding to the extent that the policy was collapsing when they were leaving office, and somebody comes in and creates a sustainable source of funding, who should have the credit?

Mr Speaker, President Mahama has created a sustainable source of funding for Free SHS. Aside from that, we have created the MahamaCares, the Ghana Medical Trust Fund; it is a social intervention policy. These have been created by the NDC Administration.

Mr Speaker, Ghana is on course, President John Mahama is on course, and the NDC is doing well and serving the people of Ghana with discipline. We will do just that, and we will do it for the people of Ghana. [*Hear!Hear*]

The Speaker: Hon Deputy Minority Chief Leader, the Hon Minister has concluded.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, this is just a point of clarification. I heard the Minister for Finance indicating that Mr Asenso-Boakye was talking about the abandonment of the project that they proposed. But that is a clear misrepresentation; yes, that is the truth. We were all here, and we know about the letter. So, I think it is mischievous, and we need to have clarity on this issue. We have it on record that he was saying that there is an existing project that is almost completed. That was his suggestion.

So, Mr Speaker, for a point of clarification, I think we should all be fair to each other. The letter did not even state that.

Thank you very much.

The Speaker: Well, Hon Minister, do you want to say something?

You are reopening the debate. I did not want to, but once you have said it, the Hon Minister has the right to reply.

Dr C. A. B. Forson: Mr Speaker, I have a copy of the letter with me. I want to send the letter to you. However, I can read the details of the letter to you.

Mr Speaker, His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, President of the Republic of Ghana— Mr Speaker, first, it is on the letterhead of the Office of the Member of Parliament, Bantama Constituency, dated 4th August, 2025, and it reads:

“Dear Mr President,

**Appeal for Reconsideration of the
New Accra-Kumasi Expressway
Proposal**

I have the honour to convey my concern on the recent proposal by your administration to construct a completely new six-lane expressway between Accra and Kumasi. As someone who has served both as Minister of Roads and Highways and a Member of Parliament representing a constituency directly linked to the Accra-Kumasi corridor, I fully appreciate the strategic importance of this route to our national economy. But it remains the most critical arterial road in this country, Ghana, linking our two largest cities and serving as a vital economic lifeline. However, Your Excellency, since John Agyekum Kufuor's administration, significant progress has been made in dualising the corridor. Over 100 kilometres of the 240-kilometre stretch have been completed,

with an additional 46 kilometres currently under active construction, including strategic bypasses at Anyinam, Osino, Anyinase and Konongo, as per the country's own records. The fiscal progress on this bypass ranges from 58 per cent to 100 per cent, with only 94 kilometres left to be dualised. The recent announcement to initiate a completely new expressway project, while these projects are underway, raises genuine concern, and I am particularly struck by the Road Minister's own admission that the Ministry is in the process of hiring a consultant to undertake the feasibility study for the new project. This suggests that there is no final design, no cost estimate, and no secured funding for the proposed expressway. Yet, Your Excellency stated publicly that construction will begin next year and be completed before your term ends.

5:12 p.m.

A timeline of less than three years. With my expertise and experience, I can say without any fear of contradiction that this timeline is not feasible. It went on to say the following,

“...With the greatest of respect, Mr President, such a pronouncement made ahead of critical project milestone like feasibility, costing, environmental clearance, and financing risk undermining our credibility in infrastructure facing and infrastructure planning and public investment management. Moreover, article 35(7) of the 1992 Constitution enjoins government to continue development project

initiated by previous administration in the national interest...”

It went on saying that:

“...abandoning an ongoing project, one that is technically sound, economically justifiable, and already delivering results, contradicts this Constitution directive and may set a bad precedent for wasteful governance...”

Mr Speaker, it went on to say that:

“...I am aware that the Minister for Roads and Highways has raised concerns about alleged cost overruns arising from project variations, which, while such claims deserve to be thoroughly investigated and if necessary, addressed through appropriate corrective measures, they should not serve as justification. They should not serve as justification for abandoning the entire project...”

It went on to say that: “... in the context of Ghana’s current fiscal constraint and competing...”—
[Interruption] I will share it. I have not shared anything. It is here. I am reading. Mr Speaker, he is not listening to me. He should listen to me; I have it here, and I am sharing it with him.

Mr Speaker, let me read everything;

“...abandoning the entire project, variations and cost adjustment are common in major infrastructure works and can be managed within existing contractual and legal framework. Discontinuing a critical national project on the basis of unresolved

variations not only undermines continuity, but also set a troubling precedent for future infrastructure development. Mr President, in the context of Ghana’s current fiscal constraint and competing infrastructure needs nationwide, I respectfully submit that it would be far more prudent to complete the existing dualisation project than to commence a new, significant, more expensive one. Mr Speaker, the resources needed for a fresh expressway could instead be channelled into completing the ongoing Accra-Kumasi dual carriageway and address other critical roads such as the Eastern Corridor, Coastal N1 Corridor, and Kumasi-Tamale Highway.

He went on to say:

“...Your Excellency, my concern is not borne out of partisanship but in the interest of continuity, prudence and national development. I respectfully urge you to review the current course and provide leadership that consolidates, and not disrupt the modest gains we have made as a country. Please accept, Your Excellency, the assurance of my highest consideration.”

Mr Speaker, clearly, this is what he said. He said that the project should not be continued. So, everybody knows what it is. [Uproar]

The Speaker: Hon Members, at the time the Hon Member referred to, made his submission, I was presiding, and exactly what the Minister read is exactly

what he submitted. No difference at all. I am sure if he had been here, he would have confirmed that. It is only that you are looking at two different sides of the same coin. It is half empty and half full. That is all that is happening. If not, it is the same thing that he submitted here.

Hon Members, we have now come to a successful conclusion of the commentary on the Statement by the Hon Minister for Finance on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government for the year ending 31st December 2026. We have other Statements, but I would be guided by Leadership as to whether we would take the Statements now or call it a day.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we had agreed that after the Leaders have concluded the comments on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, ably presented by the Minister for Finance, and having listened to his concluding remarks, we would call it a day. Tomorrow, we have quite a busy day. We want to remind Members that the State Funeral for the former First Lady would take place early in the morning from about 7:00 a.m. We want to close today so that we can come back early tomorrow to participate in that, and then return to Business at midday.

The venue for the funeral is at the Black Star Square and we want to urge Members that we all meet here and then the bus will convey us to the Black Star Square early in the morning. Between 7:00 a.m. and 7:30 a.m., we need to be there. That is why we are closing early today.

Mr Speaker, I humbly submit.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, my respected Colleague, the Minority Chief Whip, has an important matter. After that, I can now come.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the call by the Majority Chief Whip for us to draw the curtains does not find favour with us, and the reasons are not far-fetched. He should listen to me carefully. Well, effectively, we have about 13 days to ultimately pass the Appropriation.

Today, at the Business Committee meeting, we were being counselled by the Leader that there is supposed to be a programme of involvement of stakeholders at the Budget Estimate hearing. What does it mean? This is something we are doing for the first time so there is a potential that this process would drag.

I am worried that if we are not careful, this process would drag. Why? They are telling us that we should be changing our mindset and resetting, and be talking about a 24-Hour Economy? And we have a number of Motions to be prosecuted. Why are they in a hurry to go home?

Mr Speaker, we also have the Minister for Roads and Highways here. We should ask the Questions. Besides, we have about 200 Questions that are still on the shelves. They are getting dusty on the shelves. All these Questions have not been programmed, and they are in a hurry to go home.

In one breath, they are preaching 24-Hour Economy, and in the same breath, we should draw the curtains and go. We would not go home. We would work. Mr Speaker, we are opposed — they do not want to go by their own 24-Hour principles. We will stay. The Minister for Roads and Highways must answer his Questions. There are other Motions.

5:22 p.m.

The Majority Leader, at the Despatch box, was doing a lot of propaganda, now he is tired. After doing all the propaganda, now he is tired. Mr Speaker, we want to work. The Minister for Road and Highways must answer the Questions. We must take all the Motions that have been enlisted. The President is watching them. What are they doing in support of the 24-Hour Economy concept? They want to run home? No, Mr Speaker, we are opposed.

The Speaker: Hon Members, let me say that Statement time has ended. If you have to do any other Business, it will not be Statements.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

The Speaker: Are you talking about us continuing—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, Mr Speaker, on a different matter.

Mr Speaker, I have two issues: issue number one is that I drew the attention of the Minister for Finance to some substantial factual errors contained in pages 74, 75 and 76 of the Budget. I pray

that he would seek the leave of the House to amend the records in his Budget. This is a public document. I drew his attention and the record must not stay as they are because they are very substantial.

Secondly, Mr Speaker, the Chief Whip of the Majority Side is urging us to ensure we attend H. E. Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings' funeral programme tomorrow. But, regrettably, yesterday at the Requiem Mass at Ridge Church, not a single Member of the Majority Side showed up. Her daughter, Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings, is our Colleague. We again did not see any government official at the Requiem Mass. So, if he is urging that all of us must be here early enough to attend, then I would make an appeal to him that he should encourage his Side as well as Members of Government to all be in attendance. Because yesterday at the Requiem Mass, it was quite disappointing from the Government Side.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader is a leader of this House. The invitation that we have is for us to attend tomorrow's funeral. Honestly, I had no idea that there was a Requiem Mass yesterday. *[Interruption]* No, honestly. These are very serious matters. It is a state funeral. Please do not do that.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I agree with the first part of

what the Hon Minority Leader, my good Friend said, but I think what he said was in a very bad taste.

Mr Speaker, not too long ago, I was sitting on the other Side, and one former Member of this House, Hon Rashid Bawa, who was actually one of their parliamentary candidates in the Oti Region, passed. They did not even write a tribute to be read for him. We wrote a tribute, but not a single one of them even got up to contribute to the tribute at the time. That could not have been said to be an oversight. So, trying to score a political point out of this is neither here nor there.

What we are saying is that the official programme is for the funeral of the respected former First Lady and we are urging everybody to have time to go there. Those points he is making are neither here nor there. Was Parliament invited? So, he can score his political points, but I can give a plethora of occasions where people from our Side actually attended.

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I was at the mass that was held yesterday was at the Ridge Church. **[Some Hon Members: Ei!]** Hon Afenyo-Markin was not there. **[Uproar]** I was there with the General Secretary of the National Democratic Congress (NDC). **[Hear! Hear!]** I was there before the procession of the clergy into the church, so I was not late, and I was there when the clergy proceeded out. So, it is not the case that this Side of the House abandoned the mass. I was there.

So Mr Speaker, we will be there tomorrow, in our numbers. That is all I can say.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we have all been invited to be part of the funeral service of the former First Lady, H. E. Nana Konadu Agyeman-Rawlings, tomorrow, Friday, 28th November, 2025 at 7:00 a.m., at the Independence Square. So, we are urging all Hon Members to take note and make it a point to attend. This is the time to bid our former First Lady, the Mother of the Fourth Republic, farewell.

Those of you who are very young and did not work with her, we know. **[An Hon Member: Lecture]**—Hon Member, yes, that is my duty now, to lecture you. There are a lot of things you do not know, and we learned them to let you not repeat the mistakes of the past. So, we have to share that information with you. When I started sharing the information and you said, “lecture” I heard you. You know my ears are very sharp.

She is not just the mother of our Colleague, Hon Zanetor. She is the Mother of the Fourth Republic and it is through her courage, bravery, knowledge, prowess, that has elevated the role of womanhood in this country to where we are today. There were earlier starters, but what she did, please, read. We cannot let her go in silence. We have to go in our number and to sound the bugle. It is very important. So that you teach your children so that when you are also not there, you expect to be honoured the way you would honour her

tomorrow. If you do not do that, many of you may go unnoticed and unheralded. And that is no good for the development of our nation. So let us not, once again, trivialise this thing that people do not show up.

I was aware, in fact I was informed of the funeral service yesterday, but the reason it was sent to where it took place was because the intention of the family was not to attract the crowd. `

5:32 p.m.

We all know the Ridge Church. They wanted it the way it happened. Many people may not have got that information. The official card that came talks about tomorrow's event. So, I do not think it is something that should have been raised on the Floor, for it, once again, to inject some bad blood into our body politics. Please, let us be careful about these things.

Let me acknowledge, belatedly, the presence of some visitors. We have a group of students from Dietwa African Faith Basic School. It is in the Asunafo South Constituency. They are led here by the assistant headteacher, Christopher Adjei Boateng and they are 34 in number. Please, on your behalf, I warmly welcome them to the House. I am sure they have seen and heard their Members speak, and they have learned a few things which they will share at home. So, thank you for coming.

[Pupils of the Dietwa African Faith Basic School were acknowledged.]

I believe it is time for us to adjourn proceedings.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 5:35 p.m. till Friday, 28th November, 2025, at 12 noon.

Editor's Note

This Official Report was corrected by the House on 10th December, 2025.